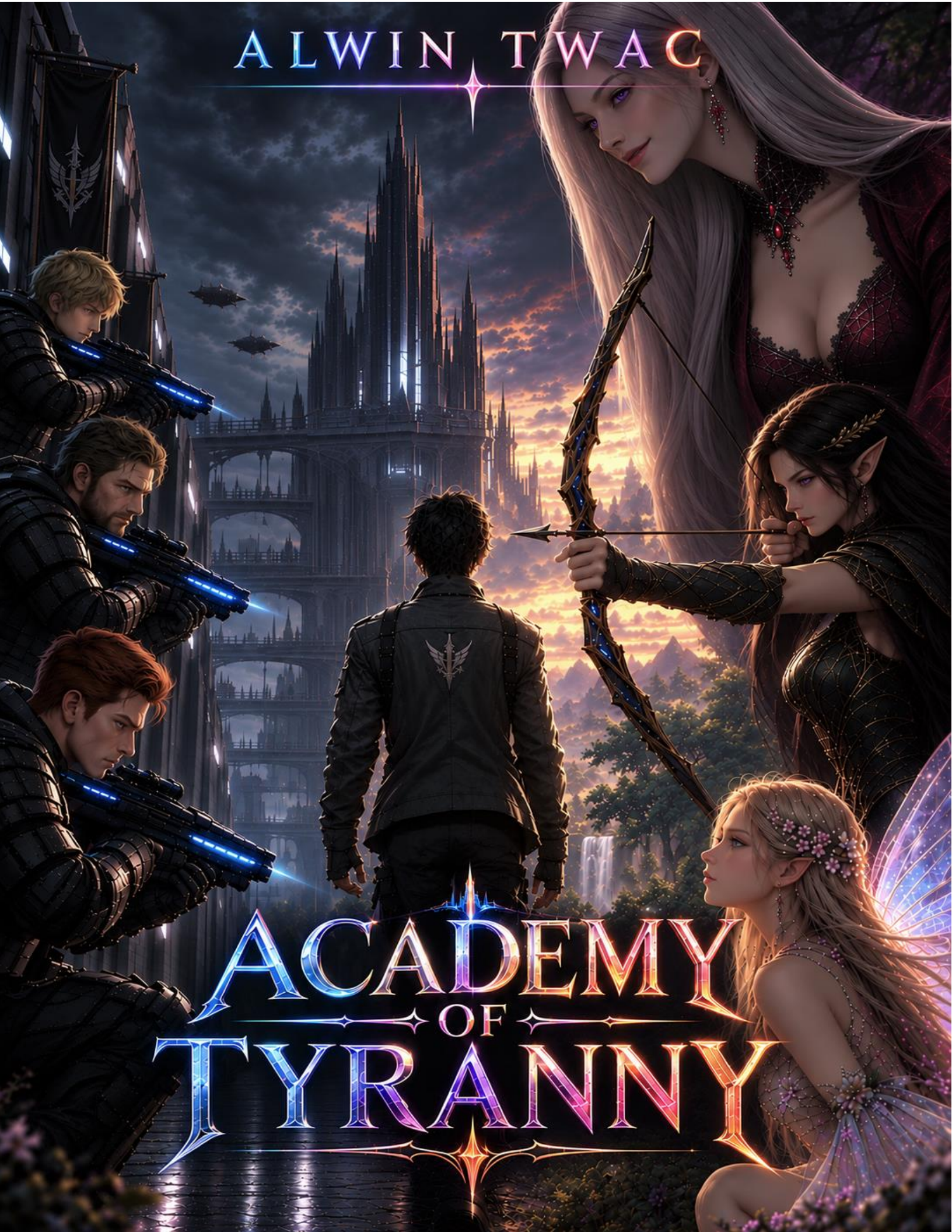

ALWIN TWAC
ACADEMY
OF
TYRANNY

ACADEMY OF TYRANNY

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# Chapter One: Today's Specials

~

*Date: 09/03/9399*

*Special Notice*

*Flash Level-up*

*-Full level EXP for eliminating a child.*

*-Double level EXP for infants below five.*

I read the announcement board twice to make sure my eyes were not deceiving me. After all, it was said prolonged exposure to the air from Earth-hollow caused hallucinations and gradual madness. But the letters did not shift, and I saw other cadets eagerly marching towards the Elsewhere gates.

*Killing a child?* That might have been the easiest experience anyone was going to get. But my mind, the only good weapon in my arsenal, began to assess the conditions of the offer.

The academy never posted a special for something common. A special was for a thing that had become scarce, or something dangerous.

"Elmer, you're doing *that* again," Lex said, nudging my shoulder. "The staring thing."

"I'm thinking."

"Think while walking. Jimmy's already at the gate."

I turned from the board. Around us, the cadets' hall hummed with the noise of men and women checking laser rifles, tightening straps, and trading rumors about which rifts had opened new hunting grounds. No one was talking about the board. That was the part that unsettled me most. No one was moved by what the words on the board meant.

Jimmy waited by the gates with his arms crossed, his broad shoulders blocking half the corridor. Beyond him, the Elsewhere portal shimmered a rippling blue, as if the air itself had been cut and was refusing to heal.

"The announcement…" I started.

"Everyone saw it," Jimmy replied. "Don't give me that look. We've been at this for six months."

“Seven in two weeks,” Lex added.

“And you’ve gained six levels. Six.” He held up his fingers as if I might not understand the number. “Lex is a level fourteen marksman who could be a level thirty by now if we weren’t hunting goblins.”

“We’re alive,” I argued.

“Barely,” Lex muttered, looking away.

For weeks, something had been eating at Lex. His gaze often drifted beyond our conversations and he’d miss half of them. He stared at the healers’ dispensary whenever we passed it, then pretended he hadn’t. I had not asked. Some mysteries a man was not meant to be asked.

“Listen,” I said, forcing my voice into the calm I used when I was frightened. “We go through the portal and head north, to the thick forests. We didn’t finish all the goblins last time. If we’re careful, we could clear two levels by mid-week. What’s on the board… that’s just pure madness.”

“Mid-week,” Jimmy repeated flatly.

“Our conscience would be clean.”

Lex was quiet for a moment. Then he said, “The villages.”

I stopped. “What?”

“All this time we thought the natives were supposed to be left alone.” He still wasn’t looking at me. “We could go there. Just look. We wouldn’t have to do anything we didn’t want to.”

“Lex.”

“I said we’ll just take a look.”

I should have heard what was underneath it. But Jimmy clapped a hand on my back and said, “The man has a point. We could be missing out. We scout, we decide. That’s fair, isn’t it?”

It wasn’t fair. It was a trap built from reasonable words. But I was the weakest of us, level twelve with no special ability, and I had already lost this argument before it began.

“*Just look*,” I said at last.

The portal swallowed us. The crossing always made my stomach turn. From our earth, the rifts opened up into Earth-hollow, were nothing but our bases and Elseworld portals existed. The Earth-hollow air had an industrial copper tang, and the sky there hung gray and motionless. From

earth hollow to Elseworld, the transition warped reality into a dazzling series of illusions, melting under our feet to spit us in the clean and crisp air of Elsewhere.

Every time, it struck me again that this world was beautiful. Sunlight fell through the exotic forest canopy in golden shafts. Birdsong, or something close to it, echoed between the trees. I had heard that this was what earth had looked like in some places, before the Avarrai took over the majority of it over a century ago.

Jimmy took the lead, his enhanced senses reading the air. He crouched often, touching the soil, tilting his head toward sounds I couldn't hear. Lex followed with his rifle shouldered, and I took the rear, scanning the trees for the sort of movement that preceded an ambush.

We walked for hours. As we climbed toward the eastern ridge, we argued that the Elseworlders were no different from the Avarrai in the ways that mattered, just smaller and weaker and easier to fight. But to be honest, the truth was plain simple, even to a person with half a brain.

The Avarrai had conquered us, and we had discovered the only way we stood a chance to reclaim earth was to level up first by preying upon the Elseworlders. This wasn't misdirected hate. It was raw desperation, and sometimes, I told my companions, desperation drove people to do questionable things.

"You complicate things," Lex said. "It's always survival of the fittest. The stronger races survive. The concept of good and evil, that's just you living a dream."

I paused, looking at him.

"Is that what you believe?" I asked.

"I believe," Lex said without turning, "that I want to go back home with a chance to fight."

"That's not an answer."

"It's the only one I have."

Jimmy said nothing. I noticed, then, that he had stopped scanning the trees. His eyes were fixed ahead. He raised a fist, and we froze.

"Ogres," he said quietly. Then, after a moment, "No. Something already passed by."

"What is it?"

"Quiet." His nostrils flared. His face, usually hard and certain, went pale. "I smell blood. A lot of it."

We crested the ridge together. The village lay in a shallow valley below us, a ring of low timber houses with thatched roofs, a well at the center, and fields of something that looked like wheat

growing beyond. It would have been a pretty picture, if not for the stillness. No smoke rose from the chimneys. No dogs barked. No one moved.

“Maybe they’re hiding,” Lex whispered.

We went down slowly, rifles raised, and the smell reached me before I saw the first body.

A man lay near the well with his hand still wrapped around a pitchfork. A woman lay beside him, her back opened by something sharp and heavy. Further on, a pair of elderly figures sat against a wall as if they had only dozed off, except for the dark stain spread down the front of them.

I saw the young ones too. They lay near the doorway of the largest house, which might have been a temple of sorts, three of them, curled against one another. The smallest could not have been four. One tiny hand still clutched a painted wooden horse.

My knees trembled. I caught myself against a wall, my stomach heaving.

“This is wrong,” I heard myself say. “Lex, they bleed. They feel pain...”

“Cadets did this,” Jimmy said. His voice was hollow. “Look at the wounds. Laser burns. Crossbow bolts.”

“Of course cadets did this!” My voice cracked, and it echoed across the empty valley. “Our people did this!”

I turned to Lex, expecting to find the same horror on his face. Instead, he stood over the smallest body, staring down. Not at the child, but at the empty air above it, where a faint shimmer lingered, like the air above asphalt on a hot day.

People called it ‘experience’. It appeared after a kill and diffused into the killer. Sometimes traces of it remained for a while. I had learnt, over the past few months, that experience was just the euphemistic word we used for a deceased soul. The Elseworld, in effect, was an unholy place that rewarded a murderer with the strength of their victim.

“All this experience,” Lex whispered. “Someone got to them before we did.”

I stared at him. “Is that what you’re thinking about?”

“I think,” he said slowly, and for the first time that day he looked me straight in the eye, “that the board wasn’t lying.”

Behind us, in the silence of the dead village, a floorboard creaked. All three of us spun, rifles rising. The door of the house adjacent to where we stood swung open by itself, and from the darkness inside came a small, wet sound.

Someone was still breathing.

# Chapter Two: One Kill

~

Jimmy moved first. He was a tank, and tanks went through doors before anyone else. He kicked it wide, rifle high, and I braced for whatever waited in the dark.

A goblin stood in the middle of the room with a woman's necklace in its fist. It was small, no taller than my chest, with mottled green skin and ears like torn leaves. It stared at us with eyes like coals, and for a moment no one breathed. Then it shrieked, and the shriek was answered from every direction.

"Scavengers!" Jimmy warned.

They poured out of the other houses as well, out of the cellars, out from under the porches: eight, ten, a dozen, wearing stolen aprons and carrying kitchen knives. They had been picking over the dead. I should have felt rage at that, but my mind was locked in a conflict, considering whether to accept the strength of adrenaline or succumb to the paralysis of fear.

My first shot took the necklace goblin in the shoulder as it leaped forward with surprising agility. My second missed entirely. Lex dropped to one knee beside me and fired with the steady rhythm of a man who had stopped being afraid of anything. Each shot sent a goblin sprawling, and each time I heard the faint hum, almost like a buzzing static around him, when he absorbed their *experience*.

We retreated towards the well when we cleared the initial wave. Jimmy unleashed his unique ability: *taunt*, forcing all the creatures in his skill range to attack him. He waded into the center of them, taking blades on his forearms and breaking skulls with the butt of his rifle.

Lex and I picked off the goblins from his sides. I killed a few. It took about ten low-life creatures like goblins to have a level's worth of experience at my current ranking. We had enough for the day, if my companions shared the same thoughts as me.

"Behind you!" Lex shouted.

I turned in time to see a goblin leaping at my face, its knife angled for my eye. I fell backward, and the laser rifle went off in my hands, and the thing hit the dirt beside me smoking. I lay there, heart hammering, staring at the sky.

That was when I heard the shouting. I rolled onto my stomach.

A girl burst out of the treeline beyond the village fields. She was perhaps nine or ten, barefoot, her dirty dress torn at the hem, her dark hair snarled with twigs. She ran with her whole body, the way only terror can make a child run. For one wild second I thought she was a survivor from the village, someone who had hidden in the woods while the slaughter happened.

Then I saw the cadets behind her. Four of them, crashing through the foliage in matching gray field jackets, rifles slung and knives drawn. They were laughing. One of them called out something I couldn't hear, and another whooped as if this were a game and she were the prize.

"Hey!" I shouted, getting to my knees. "Hey, stop, she's just a—"

She saw us. For half a second her eyes met mine across the field, enormous and dark and begging. Then she veered left, into the thick tangle of the forest, and the cadets followed. The greenery swallowed all five of them the next instant.

I tried to convince myself that I had imagined it. That I hadn't just watched four grown cadets chase a child like hunting dogs. That the world was not so broken that no one had stopped them.

"Lex?"

He was already running. I tried to follow. I got three steps before a wounded goblin's teeth latched into my shin guards. I kicked at it, and by the time I had put it permanently out of its misery, Lex had vanished into the trees. Jimmy was bellowing my name from across the village, fighting off the last of the scavengers, and for a second, I was torn between two directions.

I made the wrong choice. I stayed. I told myself later that I had stayed because Jimmy needed me. That wasn't true. The truth was uglier: I was a coward. I stood in the middle of a dead village, with a goblin bleeding out against my boot, and I let my friend walk away to do something terrible because I was afraid of what I would find if I followed him.

When the last goblin fell, the village returned to its silence. Jimmy sat on the lip of the well, his arms laced with shallow cuts. His chest rose and fell in heavy breaths. Neither of us spoke about Lex. The forest was quiet. The cadets who had given chase did not come back either.

The sun slid lower. Shadows lengthened across the fields. I was beginning to think about leaving without him when the bushes parted. Lex walked out of the treeline slowly, as if he were wading through deep water.

His face was spattered with red. It was not the sort of blood one could pick up from a goblin's death throes. His cheeks were splashed with it, his hands stained to the wrists. It was dark and thick, and there was something terrible about the way he carried it, upright and unashamed, as if he had forgotten it was there.

"Lex," I said.

He looked at me. His eyes were distant and glassy, like a man who has just surfaced from a very long dream.

"What did you do?" My voice was barely a whisper.

He did not answer. He walked past me and stood with his back to us for a long time. I watched his shoulders rise and fall.

“It’s different,” he said at last, turning to face us.

Jimmy raised an eyebrow. “What is?”

“Leveling up.” Lex’s voice was strange, almost reverent. “With goblins it’s a pinch. A little warmth on your skin. You barely notice. But this...” He pressed a wet palm flat against his chest, as if feeling for a heartbeat that was no longer his own. “It was like touching a live wire. One kill, Elmer. One, and I jumped a full level.”

I stared at him. Something within me collapsed.

“She was a child, Lex.”

“She was *Elsewhere*,” he said firmly, as if that settled it.

Lex drew some water from the well and washed his hands and face. He looked up, closing his eyes with a sense of fulfillment. His lips curled into a smile that transformed him into a completely different creature.

“And the good news,” he said, “is that there are more villages.”

# Chapter Three: Circles

~

"Say something," Lex said.

We had walked a good distance from the village before the silence between us grew unbearable. Jimmy trailed a few paces behind, favoring his left arm, his face unreadable. The forest had gone amber with late light, and every shadow looked like a place where something could hide.

"I don't know what you want me to say," I replied.

"That you understand."

"I don't, honestly."

Lex stopped walking. "Then let me explain it."

I should have kept moving. Instead I turned, and I looked at him properly for the first time since the well. The blood was mostly gone from his face, but it had left a faint stain along his jaw that water couldn't lift. His eyes were bright and feverish.

"You know what a level sixty soldier earns," he said. "Real glory back home. A chance to fight in the frontlines for something that actually matters. A medical bay that actually has medicine. I only came here for a chance to save my mother, Elmer. Where I come from… there isn't much to help with her condition. I will not pass a chance to save her before it's too late."

"I know. You've told me before."

"Then you know I don't have the luxury of being sentimental."

"This isn't sentiment. This is..."

"What is it?" he snapped. "They're not people. They look like people. They bleed like people. But the Avarrai look like people too, and nobody gives me a speech about that."

"The Avarrai *conquered* us."

"And the Elseworlders killed our scouters. The wood elves slaughtered my last party, if you need a reminder."

I wanted to say both occasions had been acts of defense. We had done exactly what the Avarrai had done to us: appeared out of nowhere and attempted to take over what was not rightfully ours.

“We’re at war,” Lex pressed. “We were always at war. The board only said out loud what everyone already knew.”

“There’s a difference between war and this… genocide.”

“Is there?” He laughed, a dry, joyless sound. “Because the way I see it, it’s just arithmetic.”

Jimmy cleared his throat. “Lex. Man. Is that really all of it? I’ve known you for a bit, and you are not always this cold.”

Lex’s jaw tightened. For a moment I thought he wouldn’t answer, and then, with the stiff embarrassment of a boy confessing to a crush on a teacher, he said, “There’s a healer. Level thirty. Her name is Marysse.”

I blinked.

“I’ve been watching her for months,” Lex continued, his voice dropping. “She’s in the third healers’ wing. She patched me up once after the goblin ambush, and I couldn’t even say thank you. Thirty, Elmer. I’m a fourteen. A level thirty doesn’t look at a level fourteen. She’ll be sent to the front before I’ve ever worked up the courage to say her name.”

“So this is for some stupid romance story,” I blurted. I did not revert my gaze from him; I wanted him to see that I was judging him in the worst possible way. “You killed a girl because you wanted a healer to notice you.”

“I’m not doing this with you, Elmer. Not today. Think what you want.”

A flock of something pale and winged burst up from the canopy and scattered into the dusk.

“You hide your bloodlust and infatuation behind a noble cause,” I said, very quietly. “I think I understand well enough.”

He didn’t answer. I looked at Jimmy, hoping that he’d take my side and talk Lex into reason. But Jimmy was staring at the ground, kicking a stone back and forth with his boot.

“He’s right about the experience,” he said at last. “We need to broaden our horizons if we wish to one day stand in the fronts. I’m sorry, Elmer.”

It felt like being struck, and it was strange, because I had expected it. Maybe that was the worst part of all.

“Then I’m done,” I said.

“What?”

“Do whatever, I don’t care. I won’t be selling my soul just to attract a girl who’s not even worth half the struggle.”

Lex’s face turned dark. I could see he was doing his best to resist the urge to throw a fist at me. I wanted him to try it. Maybe a good fist would knock some sense into him. I walked away in another direction.

“Don’t be stupid,” Lex called out. “You’ve never navigated Elsewhere without Jimmy.”

“I’ll manage.”

“Elmer...”

“Go on,” I said. “Or have you forgotten the other villages? Go and level up. I hope she notices.”

For a moment he said nothing. Then, with a voice full of spite, he spoke.

“Don’t come crying to me when you’re stuck at level twelve.”

I only raised the middle one in farewell and said nothing else. I never turned back until I there was a good deal of forest between us.

The first hour was easy. I remembered the ridge, the stream we had crossed in the morning, the oak whose trunk looked like the body of a deformed Olympian. I walked with my rifle slung across my chest, and I let myself believe that I could do this.

The second hour was harder. I passed the weird oak, and then, sometime later, I passed it again.

I told myself it was a different tree. Elsewhere was full of strange growths, and some of them were bound to look similar. But when I knelt and found the scratch I had cut into the trunk with my hunting knife, my stomach sank.

I was walking in circles. Jimmy had always been the one who knew. He would crouch, sniff the air, and say “this way” with the calm certainty of a compass. I had never needed to pay attention. I had only ever followed.

“This can’t be happening,” I muttered, laughing bitterly at my own absurdity. “After all that only to end up lost in this godforsaken place.”

The sun had been behind me when we left the village. West, then. The base lay west and south. So if I kept the sinking light on my right shoulder, I should...

The light did not hold still. Somewhere in the last hour, the canopy had thickened until the sun was only a rumor, a flicker of orange between leaves. The path I had chosen, which I was so sure was straight, kept bending away from me. Trees that had seemed so far apart were suddenly crowded close. The ground rose in strange hillocks where I’d expected it to stay flat.

By the time the last warm color drained from the sky, I had stopped pretending I knew where I was.

The forest at night was a different creature. The birds went quiet, and in their place came the small sounds that I tried to ignore; the sigh of wind through hollow trunks, and a long, distant howl that could have been a wolf or something worse. I had heard the stories at the academy. I remembered the briefing about the things that hunted after dark, the ones the scouters never agreed on names for. I needed to stop. I couldn't keep stumbling through the dark like this.

A fallen log lay beside a dense hillock, half-buried in moss. I lowered myself onto it with a groan that surprised me and pulled a ration bar from my pack. It was dry and bland and tasted like toothpaste.

For a while I just chewed, watching the dark. I thought of Lex's face at the well. I thought of the girl's eyes, and the toy horse in that tiny, lifeless hand. I wondered how many of my own people were walking Elsewhere tonight with the same feverish arithmetic in their heads.

I was halfway through the bar when I heard it. At first I took it for wind. It was thin and ragged, rising and falling in a soft rhythm. I stopped chewing. I slid off the log and crouched, rifle already in my hands, thumb flicking the safety down. The sound was close, so close it seemed to rise from beneath me. I pressed my ear against the bark.

It was coming from inside the log.

My heart was racing. Goblins did not weep. Scavengers did not weep. I edged around to the end, where the dead wood gaped open like a mouth, and I raised the rifle. The barrel light spilled into the dark.

Two pairs of eyes stared back at me. Small eyes, wet and wide and impossibly young. Two faces pressed together, their tiny hands knotted in each other's clothes.

A strange feeling crawled up my spine. A moment later, I realized it was the fear of making a choice that would define me for the rest of my life.

# Chapter Four: Turning Point

~

The barrel light trembled over their faces. A girl and a boy, pressed together so tightly I could not tell where one ended and the other began. Their hair was the same shade of dark brown, tangled with leaves and splinters. Their cheeks were streaked with dirt and tears. Their eyes were a light emerald, and both pairs were fixed on the muzzle of my rifle.

Here is a thing I am not proud of: I did the arithmetic before I felt anything else.

Full level for a child. Double if younger than five. Two children, so two levels at the very least. They looked somewhere between five and seven. I would be level fourteen by morning, as strong as Lex had been in the morning. Maybe this was the breakthrough I needed to unlock a class-worthy ability.

My finger rested on the trigger guard. It would have been so easy. My mind, the weapon I was so proud of, laid the whole case out for me in clean, reasonable lines, the way it always did. It reminded me of earth's current state, of soldiers barely holding on against the Avarrai. It whispered to me that no one would ever know.

The girl whimpered, a small, cracked sound, and pulled the boy closer.

He had stopped crying. That was what undid me. He was so terrified that he had stopped reacting, and he was holding his sister's sleeve and looking at me like I was the harbinger of death.

A vision of the three children lying on the temple floor flashed through my mind. My hands moved before my mind could argue. I thumbed the safety up, lowered the rifle, and laid it in the moss between us. I opened my palms and held them where the children could see them.

"It's all right," I said softly, though I knew the words meant nothing. "I'm not going to hurt you."

The girl stared at my hands. I realized I was shaking, too.

"Come on," I whispered. "I won't harm you, I promise."

It took a long time. I stayed where I was, sitting on my haunches with my hands open until my knees and thighs hurt from the bad posture. Neither of them moved. Once, the boy shifted, and the girl yanked him back.

Finally, the girl crawled out. She did it slowly, her eyes never leaving my face. When she was clear of the log, she stood, a tiny figure in a tattered nightshirt, and looked up at me as if I were a mountain that might fall on her. The boy followed a moment later and stood behind his sister.

I let out a breath I had been holding for what felt like eternity. Just then, I heard voices. The same voices that I heard every day when I walked towards the Elsewhere gates. Voices I never thought I'd be afraid to hear.

They came from somewhere downhill, faint at first, slipping between the trees. Men and women calling to each other in the crude language of the base, in the flat, bored tones of people who had done this before.

"Check the hollows! They can't have gone far!"

"Where is a bloody scouter when you need one?"

My blood went cold. The girl instinctively took a step back. She did not understand the words, but she understood the tone, the way every living creature understands the tone of a hunter.

Lantern light flickered between the distant trunks. I snatched up my rifle, grabbed the girl's hand, and then, without thinking, scooped the boy into the crook of my arm. He weighed almost nothing.

We plunged downhill and away from the lights, through brush that clawed at my sleeves, over roots I could not see. The girl ran beside me with her small fingers locked around mine, and she did not once slow down. Twice I heard cadets pass within a stone's throw. Once, a light swept across the trunk I was pressed against, and I held the boy's head against my chest so he couldn't make a sound.

Eventually, I found a hollow beneath the roots of a great tree, a shallow pit lined with dead leaves. I pushed the twins inside, climbed in after them, and pulled brush across the opening. We lay there in the dark, three bodies breathing too loudly.

The voices drifted. The lights flared, then faded. Somewhere above us, someone cursed about losing a good kill, and someone else laughed, and then the footsteps trudged away. They were cadets, after all, and cadets did not stay out after dark if they could help it.

When the forest was silent again, I realized I had been gripping the girl's hand hard enough to hurt. I let go.

"Sorry," I said. She only stared.

We stayed in the hollow until the cold seeped through my jacket. The woods had grown too quiet I doubted there was anyone still hunting. I got out first before the twins cautiously followed. I dug in my pack and brought out my last two ration bars.

The boy looked at his sister. She took the food first, sniffed it with suspicion, and took a small bite. Her nose wrinkled, and I almost laughed.

"I know," I said. "It's terrible."

She handed the rest to her brother, and the two of them ate in silence. I watched them and thought of how they ate: carefully, sharing, saving the larger piece for the other. Nothing about them was foreign. Nothing about them was anything but a pair of small, frightened children.

“Do you have anyone?” I asked.

The girl tilted her head.

I tried again. I pointed at them, then made a roof with my hands, then pointed into the trees, miming a house, a door, a person. I pointed to my own chest, then shrugged and spread my palms. In the end I felt stupid for even trying.

The girl watched me for a long moment. Then she lowered her eyes and said something. It was a soft sound, full of rising notes and swallowed endings, nothing like any language the academy had ever taught us. I did not catch a single word, but I heard the grief in it, as clear as if it had been spoken in my own tongue. It was the voice of someone announcing a tragedy.

The boy pressed his face into her shoulder. She stroked his hair with a hand much too practiced for a child.

“I’m sorry,” I said. It was the only thing I could say. “I don’t understand.”

She nodded as if she had expected nothing else.

I looked out into the dark and thought about what it meant. The village I had seen that morning might not have been the only one. Their home might be gone. Their parents might be lying beneath a thatched roof with a laser burn through the chest. And I had a rifle on my back, a hundred cadets between me and the base, and two children who could not tell me where to go.

There was only one answer I could think of. Elsewhere had villages. Villages meant people who might know these two, or who might shelter them. If I could get them close enough to see lights, I could leave them somewhere safe and slip away.

It was a thin plan, but it was something.

“Come on,” I said, strapping my pack to my back. “We can’t stay here. Not all night.”

The boy took my hand without being asked. His fingers were cold and sticky from the ration bar, and my heart did something strange.

We had climbed out of the hollow and taken perhaps a dozen steps when the girl froze. Her whole body went rigid. She was staring past me, over my shoulder, her eyes wide. The boy made a small sound, a high thin whine, and tried to hide behind my leg.

“What is it?” I whispered.

The girl raised one trembling finger.

I turned. The dense hillock beside the fallen log, the one I had barely noticed when I sat down to eat, was no longer still. Its mossy slope rose and fell, slowly, steadily, like the chest of something enormous.

And then, in the middle of it, a cold, orange eye the size of a dinner plate opened.

# Chapter Five: The Hunter at the Treeline

~

"Don't move," I whispered, which was ridiculous, because the girl had already gone stiff as a post.

The eye did not blink. It was the color of amber, split by a vertical pupil, and it rolled slowly in its socket until it settled on us. The moss shuddered. Clumps of earth slid from the hillock's flank as something beneath it shifted its weight, and I saw, in the thin starlight, the long, curved shape of a spine rising out of the ground.

"Back away," I breathed. "Slowly."

The boy whimpered. The sound carried.

The hillock exhaled. A wave of hot, rotten air rolled over us, and the whole slope heaved upward. Four thick legs unfolded from the soil like the arms of a drowning man. A jaw opened, wide as a doorway, lined with wide, jagged teeth.

"Run!"

I shoved the girl ahead of me, snatched the boy up, and threw myself into the trees. Behind us the thing roared, and the ground shook with its strides. I fired blindly over my shoulder, red lines of laser light stitching the dark, and I heard the shots thud into something that did not care at all.

Branches whipped my face. The boy's arms were locked around my neck so tightly I could barely breathe. Ahead of me, the girl ran with a speed that made no sense for her size, ducking under roots, vaulting a stream, glancing back only to check we were still alive.

The creature crashed through the forest behind us, snapping trunks like twigs. I could feel its breath on my back, or maybe that was my fear. My lungs were fire. My legs felt like logs.

The girl veered left, towards a gap between two enormous trees that looked far too narrow. She slid through it without slowing. I followed, turning my shoulders, scraping the skin off my arm. The boy wailed.

Behind us, there was a sickening crunch, and the roaring changed pitch. I risked a glance back. The thing had wedged its shoulders between the trunks and was howling in fury, thrashing, unable to pass. I did not stop running until I could no longer hear it.

When I finally collapsed against a tree, I was shaking so badly that I couldn't lift the rifle. The girl stood over me, panting, her small chest heaving. She looked at me. Then, to my astonishment, she laughed. It was brief, hysterical, and cracked in the middle, and it ended in a sob. But it was a laugh.

“Yes,” I wheezed. “That was a good run.”

After a brief rest, we moved on. There was nothing else to do. I had lost my pack in the chase, along with the last of my water, and my arm bled sluggishly where the tree branches had caught it. The children trudged beside me, quiet now, their strength spent.

At first they walked on their own, but as the hours dragged, their steps slowed to a point where we barely moved at all. When the girl stumbled for the third time, I crouched without speaking and she climbed onto my back. The boy walked a while longer. Eventually, he sat down in the leaves and refused to rise, and I had to switch, the girl down, the boy up, trading them back and forth until I no longer noticed which was which.

My shoulders screamed. My legs shook. But I noticed something strange. Every time the weight of a child settled against my neck, my own fear grew quieter. It was as if having someone to carry gave my body permission to be brave.

Around dawn, the girl pointed.

I stopped. Through a break in the trees, the land fell away into a long grassy slope, and at the bottom, almost hidden by the bend of a river, rose a thin thread of smoke. Chimney smoke. The smell reached me a moment later, burning wood and baking bread.

The girl said something in her soft, lilting language, and I understood it without translation.

“You know the village?” I asked, pointing, and she nodded fiercely.

I was so relieved that I felt a weight lift off my back. I had done it. I had gotten them here. I could leave them at the treeline, point them downhill, and slip away before anyone saw the cadet’s uniform. They would be safe.

We walked toward the forest’s edge together, the grass thinning under our feet. We were a few steps from the clearing when someone said, in perfect, unaccented Earth Common, “That’s far enough.”

I froze.

She stepped out from behind a wide trunk, so smoothly that I hadn’t heard a sound, as if she had been standing in that spot for an hour. She seemed to be in her mid-twenties. She wore a cadet’s gray field jacket over leather greaves, the sleeves rolled to the elbow, and a long hunting knife hung at each hip. Her hair was black and braided tight against her skull. Her skin was tan, her limbs lean and corded with muscle, and her face was striking in a way that made it hard to look away from.

She was smiling.

“Pardon,” I said. My voice cracked. “I didn’t see you.”

“You weren’t supposed to.” She tilted her head, studying the children behind me with open appetite. The girl had already ducked behind my legs. “Well. Look at that. And here I was waiting for something to wander out of the village. And what do I get?” She laughed softly. “A matched set.”

“They’re children,” I said.

“I can see that.”

“They’re lost. I’m taking them home.”

“Home” she repeated, as if the word made no sense. “That’s cute. You’re definitely a newb, or you look it, and those two are worth...” Her eyes gleamed. “Well. You know. Hand them over.”

“No.”

For a heartbeat, she looked genuinely surprised. Then the smile returned, wider, with a glint of something cold in it.

“I wasn’t asking.”

My momentary fear quickly turned into irritation.

“I said no.”

“Cadet.” She drew one knife slowly, and the steel whispered against the leather. “Let me explain how this works. I’m going to take what’s mine, and you’re going to make a choice. You can step aside and keep your life, or you can stand there like an idiot and bleed. Both are fine with me.”

The girl was clutching my leg so hard it hurt. Back home, I had no siblings. The feeling of someone relying on me, to some extent, felt new to me. I had no special ability to help me in a fight, but at that moment, the weight of responsibility gave me the courage to stand my ground.

I raised the barrel.

“They stay with me,” I said.

The hunter’s smile didn’t fade. If anything, it became delighted.

“Good,” she whispered, and she vanished.

I didn’t see her move. I only felt the wind, and the impossible speed of it, and a blade of cold light flashing toward my throat.

# Chapter Six: An Elf from the Shadows

~

I didn't die right away, and the only reason was luck.

The blade that should have opened my throat scraped across the barrel of my rifle instead, because I had flinched and thrown it up out of pure animal panic. Sparks flew. The impact twisted the weapon in my hands and nearly broke my wrists. That alone was enough to tell me the gap in our experience levels. And, unfortunately, I was dealing with the worst type: an assassin class.

I stumbled backward, and somewhere behind me I heard the twins scream and scatter into the brush.

The hunter was already beside me. I never saw her cross the distance. One moment she stood ten paces away, and the next she was inside my guard, close enough that I could smell the sweat and leather on her, and her second knife was driving toward my ribs.

I fired.

At that range I couldn't miss, but somehow I did, wildly. The beam grazed a black line through the tree behind her. She had simply leaned out of its path, the way a person steps around a puddle, and her elbow came up under my chin with a crack that rattled my teeth.

I hit the ground on my back. The sky spun. Her boot came down on my wrist and pinned it, and I felt the bones grind.

"Teen level weakness," she said, almost pitifully. "That's what's so funny. You really thought you could."

I swung my other hand for the hunting knife at my belt. She kicked it clear before my fingers touched it. I tried the fume bomb clipped to my harness, and she was there again, slicing the strap and flicking the small cylinder into the grass like a dead insect. My laser rifle, my knife, everything the academy had ever given me lay scattered around us in the dirt.

"That's enough," the woman said, thwarting my final attempt to wrestle my way out of the situation by triggering a mid-level paralysis skill. My limbs went cold.

She stood over me, breathing evenly, not even winded. The tip of her knife hung above my face, bare and gleaming, and for the first time I saw her eyes properly. They were bright, almost joyful, and entirely devoid of mercy.

"Don't take it personally," she said. "I'd have done the same to anyone."

“Why?” My voice came out as a croak. “You’re a cadet. You wear the same jacket. You’re already strong… you don’t need the children.”

“Getting to level sixty is all that matters.” She smiled, and there was something unsettling about the sweetness of it. “And *anything* that I find in Elsewhere is my sustenance.”

It took me a while to understand what she meant. Her eyes were focused on me with anticipation. She wanted me to grasp the situation, and when she saw that I had, a wicked smile played on her lips.

“You would prey on your own… for experience?”

The woman slid the flat of her blade down my cheek, until the sharp tip on the soft skin of my neck. My pulse quickened.

“I’ll give the brats a start in your honor,” she said, leaning in as she applied force on the blade. The tip drew blood. Her voice lowered into a seductive whisper. “Sweet dreams, cadet. I promise to put your levels to good use.”

Something weird happened. The woman loosened her grip. A line of blue light burst through her chest, sprouting from between her ribs, glowing and sharp. Her smile froze. She looked down at her chest, her expression surprised.

Just as quickly as it had appeared, the blade withdrew. The woman folded forward onto my legs, her braid sliding across my knees. The light went out of her eyes like the last flame of a dying lamp.

I lay there, unable to breathe, staring at the figure standing behind her.

It shimmered into being as if the air itself had decided to give it shape. First a ripple, like heat above stone, then a silhouette, then a cloak the color of old moss falling away in folds. The figure was tall, with long limbs and a narrow, severe face under a hood. A thin, pointed ear showed through a lock of silver hair. In its hand was a sword whose blade burned a faint, living blue.

An elf. She stepped over the hunter’s body. Her gaze fell on me, cold, level and weighing, and I knew without being told that she was deciding how I would die. The paralysis was thawing, but I still couldn’t move. My weapons lay in the grass, out of reach. Somewhere in the distance a bird began to sing, as if nothing was wrong with the world at all.

The elf lifted her blade.

“*Neur!*”

It was a child’s voice, high-pitched and urgent. A small figure darted out of the tall grass and stood near my head, arms flung wide. The girl. She looked ridiculously small against the elf’s

towering shadow. But she did not move. She said something, a long, rushing stream of words in the strange tongue, her voice breaking and her hand gesturing wildly at me and then at the dead hunter.

The elf's blade stopped.

For a long moment, nothing happened. The blue light pulsed against the elf's face, throwing hard shadows over her cheekbones. Her eyes flicked from the girl to me, then to the boy who had summoned the courage to stand by his sister, then back to me. Something shifted in her expression, too fast for me to read.

She lowered the sword, slowly, and slid it into its sheath without a sound.

I was about to say something when the elf raised her boot. I saw the sole descending, wide and heavy and studded with something metal.

Then the world went black.

# Chapter Seven: Finding a New Team

~

Cold woke me.

It was the deep, bone-settling cold of damp earth and dew, and for a few seconds I lay there trying to remember why my face felt like it had been split down the middle. Then the memory arrived all at once: the hunter's smile, the blue blade, the girl standing between me and the elf with her arms flung wide.

I sat up too fast, and the world swung sideways. My jaw screamed. I pressed my fingers to it and felt a swollen ridge along the bone, and when I spat, the grass came away pink. Somewhere above me, the sky had gone crimson. I could not tell whether that meant dusk or dawn.

The twins were gone. So was the elf. I turned in a slow circle, searching the long grass, the treeline, the bend of the river below, hoping for a flash of dark hair or a small, scuffed foot. There was only the wind combing the stalks, and the distant thread of smoke rising from the village.

They had gotten home. That was what I told myself. The elf had walked them down the slope, and the girl had spoken to someone, and somewhere in that cluster of thatched roofs, two children were curled in warm blankets. It was a good story. I held on to it.

The hunter was still there.

She lay on her side a few paces away, one arm flung out as if reaching for something. A fly had settled on her cheek. Without the cruelty animating it, her face looked startlingly young, barely older than the freshman cadets I had seen at the academy's welcome ceremonies. A hole the width of a blade had burned through her jacket, and the leather around it had gone black.

My weapons were scattered where she had kicked them. I gathered them one by one, the laser rifle, the knife, and checked each with shaking hands. The rifle still hummed when I thumbed the power. The knife was fine. The cylinder had rolled into a hollow, and I found it by luck and held it in my palm for a moment, thinking about how many people had died with a weapon in reach and no time to use it.

I went to the hunter's body and closed her eyes, which was all I could think of. Then I turned my back on the village and started walking.

I would like to say that I navigated by cleverness. I did not. I walked, and I prayed, and by the time the sky went dark, I had located a group of cadets returning to the base, talking zealously about their hunt. I followed at a distance.

When they finally reached the Elsewhere portal and vanished into the blue, I crept to the shimmering oval and stepped through after them.

The crossing through Earth-hollow was grayer than I remembered, and the base looked like the gates of heaven.

Floodlights. Concrete. The smell of boiled cabbage and machine oil, and the dull, mechanical hum of a place that never slept. I had once hated this building with its sterile corridors and stale air. Now I could have wept at the sight of its walls.

The registry desk was unmanned, as usual. I scanned my badge at the console, and the machine blinked and recorded my return without comment. *Cadet Elmer Leich, Level 12. Status: Active.*

I rescanned. The result was the same. I stared at the number until the words blurred.

Still twelve. Two days of hell, and I hadn't gained a single level.

***

I found Lex and Jimmy in the mess hall that evening.

They sat at their usual table by the vending machines, the one with the crooked leg that Jimmy kept wedging with a folded napkin. Lex had his back to me. Jimmy faced the door, and he saw me the moment I walked in. His fork stopped halfway to his mouth.

For a second I thought he would wave. I think he almost did. Then Lex turned, and my heart sank.

He looked different. It wasn't the clothes, or the haircut he must have gotten while I was gone, or the faint scar over his left eyebrow. It was something about how he held himself, the unfamiliar ease in his shoulders, the quiet, coiled readiness of a man who has stopped being afraid of what's around him.

No one said anything. The clatter of trays and the mutter of other conversations flowed around us like water around a stone. Lex held my gaze for a long moment, and I saw a dozen things cross his face, guilt, defiance, a flicker of the old friendship. Then he looked down at his plate, and the shutters came down.

I stood there like a fool, waiting for someone to speak. Jimmy opened his mouth, closed it again, and glanced at Lex. I took my tray and sat at the far end of the hall.

The next two days dragged. I ate alone. I slept badly. I lay on my bunk at night and stared at the ceiling, wondering whether the twins were safe, whether the elf had really let them go, whether the board in the hall would be updated tomorrow with new numbers.

I wondered, too, whether I was strong enough to keep refusing.

It would be so easy to stop. To go back to Elsewhere, find a child, and pull the trigger the way Lex had. The thought did not come as temptation anymore. It came as arithmetic, patient and quiet, and I hated that I could follow it so well.

But I couldn't forget the hunter. If there were others like her, then there was no safe place in this building, no friendly face I could trust. And if the truth was that no one was safe, then the wisest thing I could do was find myself someone I could stand to fight beside.

I tried. I approached every party that gathered at the gates, and I did that for two days straight. I was a level twelve with no special skills, no healer, and no reputation, and they looked at me the way one would look at a stray dog in a rainstorm. The kindest said no. The rest simply didn't answer.

On the third evening, I was sitting alone in my bunk bed, thinking of a future that would never happen when someone entered the room.

"Here's my guy with free time."

I looked up.

He was perhaps thirty, lean and loose-limbed, with unruly sandy hair and a grin that seemed permanently on the edge of a joke. He wore no armor, only a black combat jacket and fingerless gloves, and two short blades crossed at the small of his back. A small, pentagonal badge of silver was clipped to his shirt collar. It was a symbol that separated the level fifty and above from nobodies like me.

I scrambled to my feet. "Sir."

"Don't call me sir, it makes me feel old." He studied me for a moment. "Kyle. I've heard rumors that you've been desperate to find a hunting team."

I felt pride and embarrassment all at once. I could have told the man he was mistaken, but I was, indeed, desperate.

"I... Yes."

"Good." His grin widened. "I've got a job. There's a castle a couple of weeks north, a vampire nest according to the scouters, and I intend to clear it. Could be enough to push me past sixty." He shrugged. "I need someone to carry my gear. Water, rations, spare blades. You'd stay behind me and keep your head down. If I live, I'll toss you something worth about three levels. Or four, I am not sure how much a vampire grants."

"You want me as your... porter?"

"Baggage boy," Kyle said with a smile. "Don't pretend it's a prettier word."

I could have said yes immediately. Three levels, and a top-level cadet at my side. Yet something in the back of my mind was pulling at me, a warning I couldn't name. It was foolish to ignore my primal instincts at this point after what I had gone through, but my choices were nonexistent. I was on the verge of starving, and I was being offered a piece of bread that had the possibility of being poisoned.

"Well?" Kyle said after a while. "Do we have a deal?"

# Chapter Eight: Baggage Boy

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"Yes," I said.

I said it before I could talk myself out of it. Kyle's grin returned at once, bright and easy, and he clapped me on the shoulder hard enough to make my recovering jaw throb.

"Smart kid. We leave at dawn. Bring water, bring rations, bring whatever you need for the journey." He walked outside, then paused at the door and glanced back. "And baggage boy? Try not to die in the first week. It's bad for morale."

The first thing I learned about Kyle was that he never walked in a straight line.

He drifted. He angled left, then right, then circled back for no reason I could see, his head cocked as though he were listening to music only he could hear. By the second day I realized it was deliberate. He was reading the land, testing the shadows, making sure that nothing was following us and nothing was waiting ahead. The loose, careless swagger was a mask. Underneath it, he was the most watchful man I had ever met.

The second thing I learned was that he was fast.

Not fast like Lex, whose speed came from instinct and nerves. Kyle was fast like water finding a crack. On the third day we met a party of five ogres at a river crossing, each about nine feet tall, hauling bundles of wet lumber toward a camp I hadn't seen. I dropped my pack and fumbled for my rifle. By the time I had it up, the first ogre was already toppling.

Kyle had vaulted over its shoulder, slit its throat, and landed on the next one's back. A blur of black jacket and silver blades. The second ogre bellowed. The third swung a tree trunk of an arm, missing Kyle by a mile. He was behind it, driving both knives into the base of its skull, and the great body folded like wet paper.

The faint, crackling static of experience rose from the corpses. I felt a pang of something, not quite envy, not quite horror. He took it all without even slowing. Before I knew it, the fight was over.

Our second encounter was a woman that we found at a river crossing. She stood by the river bank, wearing a travel-stained cloak and carrying a deflated, torn traveling bag. She was young, with a kind, tired face that had seen better times.

"Can you spare some food?" the woman asked, looking at Kyle.

Kyle paused before the log bridge and rummaged through his pockets. The woman walked towards us.

The hair on the nape of my neck stood erect, and I instinctively fumbled for the trigger. The woman hesitated, but only for a moment. Then I saw it. Her reflection. The currents were steady, but her reflection was nothing but twisting black smoke.

Kyle took a step forward to hand over a protein bar. The woman reached out.

“Thank you,” the woman said.

Without thinking twice, I aimed my rifle and fired. The beam took her in the chest. She screamed, and the scream rippled, stretching and twisting, and then her flesh shifted like clay in a potter’s hands. Her face lengthened. Her arms bent backward. In a heartbeat, she was a gray, hairless thing with too many joints and a mouth full of needle teeth, reaching for Kyle as it fell.

I shot again and again, pouring laser fire into its shifting form. The creature twitched once on the stones and went still. I felt the experience static a minute later, and only then did I tuck away my rifle.

Kyle stood still, looking at the steaming mass of burnt gray flesh.

“I’d be damned. A *changeling*.”

“A what?”

“A changeling,” Kyle repeated. “They steal forms through physical touch. They are not very formidable in combat, so they rely on these tricks. If it weren’t for you, it’d be wearing my skin right now. How did you notice it wasn’t human?”

“The shadow in the water,” I explained. My heart was still pounding. “It looked… off.”

“And here I thought I was the better hunter,” Kyle said, taking a bite at his protein bar. “An act of kindness nearly got me killed. Thank you, Elmer, for giving me the chance to live to correct it.”

The following days had no incident, save for the occasional goblin parties which Kyle had no trouble clearing. I managed to harvest a few scraps, but I could tell I was not evolving at all. My senses and reflexes remained exactly the same.

The landscape changed, forests thinning into rolling moors, then into rocky hills bleached by wind. The air grew colder. On some evenings Kyle lit a small fire and cooked things that smelled better than they had any right to, and I sat across from him, sharpening my knife and listening to him talk.

He talked easily, about nothing. The best ration vendors in his home town. A gambling game he’d lost his boots in. A level forty tank in the base’s western quarters who had stolen his heart only to die a month later during a dragon hunt. He never talked about levels or kills. Never about

the war with the Avarrai back home. He navigated around the fronts, and I realized he might have lost something there that time could not effectively heal.

By the tenth night, we had passed three villages. Small ones, tucked into valleys, with smoke rising from their chimneys and fields shining under the day end sun. Cadets had not yet explored the villagers here, and we even spotted some children running through some fields a couple of times.

Kyle looked at them with longing, his ruddy face softening for an instant before the Elseworld reminded him that joy was an emotion he could not afford. One night, I waited until the fire had burned low, and the silence between us had settled. Then I said, as lightly as I could, “You don’t go after the villages.”

“No.”

“Why not?”

He kept poking the fire. “Nothing worth hunting in a village.”

“There’s experience.”

“There’s a few levels’ worth of children and farmers,” he said. “That’s not hunting. That’s harvesting.” He shrugged. “I like prey that fights back. Something that can make me better.”

I picked at a loose thread on my sleeve. “Do you think it’s right? What we’re doing here? Killing Elseworlders for experience?”

Kyle laughed.

It wasn’t a cruel laugh. It was gentle and amused, the way you’d laugh at a child asking why the sky is blue. He leaned back against his pack and looked up at the stars.

“Moral questions,” he said. “Yes. I wondered when you’d get around to them. You’ve got that look, you know. The one the sentimental ones always get.”

“I’m just asking.”

“I don’t care that much, Elmer.” The words came out flat and light. “Right, wrong. Somebody up there decided we’re at war, and so we’re at war. I get my levels. I go home to fight on the frontlines. I get a better life, if I live. That’s morality enough for me.”

“You avoided the question.”

“I told you what I think.” He turned his head. The firelight carved his face into hard planes, and for one moment his usual charm was gone, and I saw what lay beneath. Something tired.

Something very old. “If it’s eating you up this much, then quit. Go home. The barracks are always short of general hands, you can find your purpose there. Nobody will think less of you.”

“I can’t.”

“Then you’d better learn to live with it.” He sat up. “And while you’re learning, learn this. One of these days you’re going to meet a fellow cadet who wants what you have. Maybe in a forest, maybe in a corridor, maybe over a plate of soup. They’ll smile at you, and they’ll have a knife behind their back. You need to be strong enough, both in your body and your head, to kill whoever stands in your way.”

I stared at him.

The fire popped. A log shifted, sending a ribbon of sparks into the night.

“Have you?”

The question hung between us, cold and unanswered. Kyle’s expression didn’t change. He reached for the pot, poured himself a cup of what he called ‘jungle tea’, and took a long, unhurried sip. When he finally looked at me again, the charm was back, smooth and bright and perfectly in place.

“Get some sleep, Elmer,” he said gently. “We’re nearly there.”

I lay awake long after the fire had died, listening to his slow, even breathing, and wondering how many baggage boys he had walked with before me, and whether any of them had ever asked the right question in time.

# Chapter Nine: The Castle in the Snow

~

The mountain appeared on the thirteenth morning.

I had been watching the horizon for days, half expecting it to rise out of the mist like a tooth. Instead it simply was there when I woke, vast and white and silent, its peak lost in a bank of low cloud. Snow had begun to fall during the night, thin and dry, and it squeaked under our boots as we climbed.

The castle sat in the mountain's flank as if it had grown there.

There were no crumbling towers or sagging roofs as I had expected. The walls were black stone, smooth as glass and untouched by frost, and the spires rose in elegant spirals against the gray sky. Lights burned in a lot of narrow windows. Smoke curled gently from a high chimney. It looked inhabited. It looked *cared for*, and somehow that was far worse than a ruin.

Kyle stopped at the lip of the last ridge and crouched, resting his forearms on his knees. For a long time, he said nothing. The wind tugged at his jacket and stirred the sandy hair on his forehead.

"Pretty," he murmured.

"Is that normal? For a nest?"

"Nothing about vampires is normal." He rose and brushed the snow from his gloves. He took a wooden blade and a strange bronze dagger from the bag I carried. "Right. Rules. Keep our arsenal ready at all times. Be ready to throw me what I ask you to at any given time. You stay behind me, close enough to touch my back, and you don't wander. You don't speak unless I speak first. If I say run, you run, and you don't look to see why. Understand?"

"Understood."

"Say it."

"If you say run, I run."

"Good." He grinned, but his eyes were hard. He drew his two short blades and rolled his shoulders once, twice, like a swimmer about to dive. "Let's go and see how much trouble we can cause."

There were no guards.

I kept waiting for them. At the end of the long, snow-swept causeway, beneath the great arched gate, I expected to see sentries, or hounds, or at least a chained gargoyle. There was nothing. The gate stood open. A faint, sweet scent drifted out of it, like pressed flowers and fresh wine, and the sound of our footsteps was swallowed by the quiet.

The front doors were twice the height of any man, carved from some dark, glossy wood and bound with silver. They stood slightly ajar, as though someone had just stepped inside.

Kyle paused, pressed one palm against the frame, and listened.

“Strange,” he whispered. “No traps. No wards. Either they’re careless or they’re very, very sure of themselves.”

He eased the door open and slipped inside. I followed, my rifle held tight against my chest, and the warmth of the hall folded over me like a hand.

It was vast. A single chamber of black marble rose three floors above us, lit by chandeliers whose candles burned without wavering. Tapestries covered the walls, deep crimson and gold, depicting scenes I tried not to look at too closely. A grand staircase curved up the far side, and a long gallery ringed the second level, lined with pillars and shadows.

At the center of the floor stood a man.

He had not been there when we entered. I would have sworn to it. But he stood now with perfect stillness, hands clasped behind his back, as if he had been waiting for hours. He was tall, and strikingly handsome, with a face carved from moonlight: high cheekbones, a straight nose, lips just slightly too red. His hair fell in dark waves to his shoulders. His skin was so pale it seemed to glow. He wore a long coat of midnight blue, buttoned with silver, and he regarded us patiently as if his sole purpose had been to wait for us.

“Gentlemen,” he said. His voice was warm, cultured and faintly amused. “I do hope you haven’t come to be rude.”

Kyle smiled.

“That depends,” he said. “Are you going to be polite about dying?”

The vampire’s eyes flickered, red as embers in a banked fire. “How tedious. You always say that.”

“Do I?”

“Your kind.” He sighed and unclasped his hands. Long fingers, sharp nails. “Well. If you insist.”

He moved.

I did not see it. I only heard it, a crack like a whip, and then Kyle was no longer standing in front of me. The marble where he'd been had cracked in a starburst, and he was a dozen feet to the left, skidding backward in a crouch, a thin red line opening across his cheek.

The vampire stood where Kyle had been, one hand extended, his fingertips glistening.

"Fast," he said approvingly. "For a human."

"You too," Kyle breathed. "For a vampire."

He lunged. I had never seen anything like that fight. In the low plains, I had seen high level cadets hold their own against orc champions. They had been agile, fast, and strong, but I had *seen* them. This was completely beyond my plane of comprehension.

They crossed the hall in blurs, trading blows too fast for the eye to follow. I caught only fragments: the flash of a blade, the ring of steel against something harder, a spray of sparks as Kyle's knife scored the vampire's forearm and the wound sealed in the same breath. The vampire laughed. Kyle did not. He slid under a clawing strike, spun, drove an elbow into the vampire's ribs, and was already gone before the counterblow landed.

I stood there, waiting for a signal to do something. But with the way things were going, I was more of a hindrance than an asset. Something wet struck my cheek, and I didn't wipe it away because any movement I made would likely end poorly for me.

"The glass vial!" Kyle shouted.

I fumbled with the straps. My fingers trembled. The bag seemed to be filled with everything but the vial. The fight did not stop while I panicked, and I half expected the vampire to swing a clawed hand across my throat. Eventually, I found it under a coiled rope and tossed it at the blur that I assumed was Kyle.

The glass vanished in mid-air, swiped away by the vampire's hand. He was onto me that very instant, and I did not have the time to react. Even if I had a second, it was not enough to unharness my rifle. All I could do was close my eyes and bring my arms up to shield my head.

I heard a sharp squelch. A low gasp followed immediately after. I slowly lowered my arms and watched. The wooden blade was piercing through the vampire's heart from behind. The vampire's mouth opened as though to speak, and nothing came but a slow, dry rattle.

Then he began to crumble.

It started at the wound and spread outward, the skin graying, cracking, flaking away like ash from a burned page. His hands fell to dust. His face followed, handsome to the last, the expression of baffled disbelief lingering until the final instant. The coat collapsed upon itself, empty. A pile of fine gray powder settled across the marble, and a draft stirred it, and it drifted apart.

Silence.

Kyle stood over the remains, chest heaving, one hand pressed to his bleeding arm. He looked at the dust. He looked at the stake in his hand. And then he began to laugh, a breathless, startled laugh, wild with relief.

“These things are more difficult than I expected,” he said. “You made a good bait. Now let’s…”

He broke off. A soft sound had drifted down from above us, so light that I might have imagined it. The whisper of fabric moving through the air.

I looked up.

On the gallery above, a shape stood against the railing, outlined by the glow of the chandeliers. Slender, regal, wrapped in a gown of dark smoke that curled and flowed around her like living shadow. Her hair was a cascade of silver, her skin pale like bone china. Her eyes were the deep violet of a coming storm, and they were fixed not on us, but on the heap of ash on the marble floor.

She floated over the railing. Then she descended, slow and graceful, the smoky gown billowing around her, and landed on the marble a few yards in front of us without making a sound.

For a long moment, she only looked at the empty coat. Something passed across her face, too quiet to be grief, too deep to be anger.

“I did tell him,” she said at last, softly. “I told him he was too confident for his own good.”

She lifted her head, and her violet gaze settled on Kyle. I felt the temperature in the great hall drop, as though winter itself had walked in through the open doors.

# Chapter Ten: True Power

~

"Turn back."

She said it gently, the way you might tell a child not to touch a hot stove. The smoke of her gown settled around her ankles, and she folded her hands in front of her, calm as a queen receiving petitioners.

Kyle did not move. Blood ran from the cut on his cheek. In his right hand, the wooden blade still smoked with a faint, gray residue.

"Excuse me?" he said.

"Turn back," she repeated. "Take your baggage carrier and go down the mountain. I do not wish to kill you." Her violet gaze drifted over the heap of ash. "I dislike killing. It is so very untidy, and it always seems to happen in the front hall. You have already removed one of my household. I will call that a misunderstanding. I will forgive the intrusion, and I will clean the mess you have left behind. Go."

It was the strangest offer I had heard up to date. I stood frozen behind Kyle, the rifle suddenly feeling like a hundred pounds in my grip, trying to decide whether she was lying. Her voice carried no threat. No anger. She sounded tired, almost bored. And somehow that terrified me more than any scream could have.

Kyle laughed.

"You hear that, Elmer?" he said over his shoulder. "She's *forgiving* us."

"Kyle..."

"I just killed her mate, and she wants to send me home with a pat on the head." He rolled the stake in his fingers and grinned at the woman. "Vampires are not that kind. Sorry, sweetheart. I came for at least twenty levels and your boyfriend was just not enough. No offense."

"He was not my mate," she said patiently. "He was a foolish disciple who mistook cleverness for strength." Her gaze seemed to pierce through our souls. "You, I think, are making the same mistake."

"Kyle..." I said. "Something's wrong. Look at her."

"What about her?"

"She hasn't moved. She hasn't *breathed*."

It was true. I had been watching her for a full minute, and her chest had not risen once. There was no sign of tension in her shoulders, no flicker of calculation in her eyes. The first vampire had been fast and vicious and eager to fight. This one stood like a statue at the bottom of a lake, and every instinct I owned was screaming at me to run.

Kyle only chuckled. He reached back and patted my arm like he was soothing a nervous horse.

“It’s fine, Elmer. I’ve got this.”

I will tell you what I saw, though I am not sure it is the truth.

Kyle crossed the hall in a single bound, faster than I had ever seen him move. His two blades flashed in the chandelier light, one high, one low, aimed at throat and belly. A killer’s strike, flawless, meant to end the fight before it began.

Then the world changed. There was no blur, no sound, no displacement of air. One moment Kyle was in mid-stride, the white of his teeth bared in a fierce grin. The next, the woman was simply standing in front of him, close enough to embrace.

Her hand was *inside* his chest. I do not remember her moving. I do not remember the sound it made. I remember that Kyle’s grin stayed on his face for a heartbeat too long, as though the expression had not been told to leave. His blades dropped from his fingers and rang against the floor. His eyes widened.

The woman withdrew her hand slowly, and with it came something dark and glistening that still twitched. She held it up to the light of the chandelier and turned it, studying it with the tender fascination of a child examining a beetle. It beat once more in her palm. Then it stilled.

Kyle fell. He didn’t crumple, or stagger, or cry out. He simply folded, his knees giving way, his body sliding sideways across the polished stone.

The faint shimmer rose from his body. A thin, pale haze drifted upward, brighter than any I had seen, and it hung in the air for a long moment, as if reluctant to depart. Then it curled toward the woman and vanished into her skin.

She did not even notice.

“Poor thing,” she murmured, and let the heart fall from her fingers.

I did not notice when I dropped the rifle.

I heard it clatter against the floor, a distant, meaningless sound. My legs had stopped working. My mouth was open, but nothing came out. Kyle was dead. An elite assassin, the strongest man I had ever accompanied in this cursed world, dead in less time than it took to blink. And he had told me he had this.

The woman's head turned ever so slightly. Her eyes found me, and I felt them like ice stabbing at my soul. She looked at me for a long, slow moment, from my muddy boots to the bruise on my jaw to the useless rifle at my feet. A faint furrow appeared between her brows.

"And what," she said, "are you?"

She started towards me.

She did not hurry. Her steps were slow and graceful, each one soundless on the marble, and with every one the air grew colder. Frost bloomed across the floor in delicate, feathered patterns. My breath clouded white. The candles in the chandeliers guttered and bent toward her, as if bowing. I tried to back away, but my heels were stuck to the floor.

She stopped an arm's length from me. Her hand was still stained to the wrist, but she held it away from her body, politely, the way one held a dirty glove.

"Humans," she said at last. "In my halls. I do not mind the occasional visits. I do mind the disrespect." She looked at me in a puzzled, almost wistful way. "You are younger than the other. Weaker. Frightened, too. And yet, you did not run."

"I couldn't," I whispered and felt embarrassed by how pathetic I sounded.

"No." A faint smile touched her lips. "I suppose not."

She stepped closer. The cold rolled off her in waves, and my teeth began to chatter uncontrollably.

"I am curious," she stated. "You two are not like any humans I've seen in this world. There is something that I can't place my finger on..." Her violet eyes searched my face. "You wear strange clothes and bear strange weapons. You kill unprovoked and refuse to see to reason because of some unexplainable bloodlust. Perhaps there is something in you worth understanding. Perhaps I might find something *interesting*."

"Please," I said. It came out as a croak. "Please, I'm nobody. I'm only a porter."

"Yes. That is what I thought." Her smile widened a fraction. "Follow me."

I tried to refuse. I swear I did. I opened my mouth to say something, and my legs moved instead.

It was the most horrifying thing I had ever felt. My body obeyed her the way a hand obeys the mind, smoothly, effortlessly, without any sense of force. My knees bent. My feet stepped forward. I felt myself walking across the frozen marble behind her, past Kyle's body, past the heap of gray dust, and my own mind screamed from somewhere deep inside as though from the bottom of a well.

Up the grand staircase, beneath the swaying chandeliers. Down a long gallery lined with portraits of faces too pale and too beautiful to be real. Through a pair of tall black doors that swung open before she touched them.

The room beyond was a study.

Shelves climbed to a vaulted ceiling, crowded with books and glass jars and strange brass instruments. A long table stood in the center, scarred and stained, laid with knives and tongs and tiny silver saws, each gleaming in neat rows. The air smelled of herbs and disinfectant.

The woman lifted a small silver bell from her desk and rang it once.

A door opened somewhere behind us. A young woman in a gray servant's dress hurried in, her head bowed, her hands folded. She dropped into a curtsy so low that her forehead nearly touched the floor.

"Mistress."

"A guest," the vampire said without turning. "He is filthy. Clean him." She paused, and a dark smile formed on her lips. "Raw."

The servant lifted her clear blue eyes to mine. They held a quiet, hollow sympathy, the look of someone who had done this many times before and knew exactly how it ended.

"Please follow me," she said, her voice so sweet and tender it stopped my nerves from wracking themselves as soon as the words reached my ears. I followed behind the woman, my mind resting more at ease the more the distance extended between me and the vampire.

As I passed the doors, my thoughts unclouded for a second. Then it dawned on me. The servant was not making me feel comfortable: she had just placed a different type of control on me.

# Chapter Eleven: An Immortal's Pet

~

I never knew the true meaning of pain until the vampire strapped me to her table. I had never imagined that my body would be explored like a new planet. The vampire dug in with childlike fascination and took what she found interesting.

I stopped counting days. At first I tried. I scratched marks into the stone beside the table with a fingernail, one for every time the servant brought the towel to clean up the mess, but I am afraid my mind succumbed to the horrors sooner than I could have wanted. Time slid apart in that room. There was only the table, the cold, and the long, patient scrape of silver against bone.

I did not have the capacity to track everything she did, but I comprehended the methodical procedure she used to decrypt the mystery of my existence. The first thing she did was take away my dignity by strapping me to the table without a strip of clothing. Then she got to work.

She did not use an anesthetic. The coldness of her presence seemed to drain all my energy every time she made physical contact with me, so in the end all I could do was stare.

She tested my physical constitution by dissecting through my veins. She broke more bones than I care to name to see cross-sectional area detail. She opened my chest like it was a Christmas present, pinning my heart with some needles and scribbling something in a notebook. After it was apparent to her that I could not heal on my own, she injected a syringe of what I assumed was her blood into me, and the wounds stitched themselves closed overnight.

The next thing she did was test my nervous system. I will not speak much of what she did with her scalpels and scissors, but I remember trying to cry and failing. I could not do anything, even bat an eyelid, unless she permitted it. In the end, she scribbled in her notebook again, and left when she felt the sport had grown too cold.

She came in the mornings, always, and during all that time, she never spoke a single word to me. By the third session, my body felt like one big bruise from the inside out. This time, she wanted to examine my mind. Her claws extended, and she reached out, two piercing through the corners of my eyes, two through my ears, and they went in until I felt the sharp tips touch something soft that was not meant to be tampered with.

The vampire took in my memories with the interest that I had once felt when I learnt Rayleigh scattering. She forced me to relive every nightmare, every mistake, and every regret. I did not know what she had expected to find, but by the time she was finished, a cold sweat trickled down her temples. She left abruptly, and the servant entered shortly thereafter, carrying her usual bucket and towel.

The servant, whose name I had heard was Maitah if my ears served me correctly, washed me carefully and she never spoke above a whisper. Her touch calmed my mind, and I suspect that was her supernatural ability, but it did not ease the pain.

For the first time, she lifted my head and pressed a silver cup to my lips. A cold liquid trickled down my throat, and I could not tell what it was because my taste buds were not responsive.

“The Mistress has found your nature pleasing. That is the only reason you are alive.”

*Was that supposed to comfort me?*

“No,” Maitah said, wiping sweat from my brow. “It is only true.”

On what I judged to be the fifth evening, the vampire sat down beside the table, folded her hands in her lap, and said, “I apologize for my rudeness.”

An unspoken command came into my mind, prompting me to turn my head towards her. My neck creaked. I think she had broken it deliberately some days ago when she was learning more about how my vertebra worked.

“I never properly introduced myself.” She smiled, and in the candlelight, her violet eyes were almost kind. “My name is Feonna. Of the House Vieldorblom. My ancestors were a great deal way back, or so I heard. It matters not now. I permit you to use my name.”

“My name is Elmer,” I found myself saying.

I had not been controlled to say it. It felt strange. Why would I answer her after everything she had done to me? Physically, I was healing thanks to her blood. But she had broken the only thing that mattered to me. She had broken my spirit. Maybe that’s why I answered. Maybe I had realized I was fighting a losing battle and nothing I did or *didn’t* do was going to change it.

“I know,” she said. She almost smiled. “Elmer. Your mother had a strange way of saying it. It is a good name.”

Tears flooded my eyes unbidden. My past was one thing I wished to keep buried. Pretending I had moved on was my only way to cope.

Feonna rose and crossed to the shelf of thick books. For a moment, she stood with her back to me, running one slim finger along the row.

“There was a time when I used to think that all creatures could co-exist if they managed to communicate,” she said. “I believed that all our wars, the killing, was just a misunderstanding. I devoted my life to do something useful. I wanted to bring peace to this world.”

She turned to face me.

“Do you know what I found, Elmer?”

I shook my head quietly.

“I found a means to communicate with other races. I made them see the merits of coexistence. But, to my own shame, I discovered that people will always choose their own interests over ideal morals, even when they know what they are doing is wrong. I had wasted a few centuries on nothing but a fantasy.”

I had guessed that Feonna was *old*, but when she spoke of centuries like they meant nothing, it got me wondering how ancient she truly was.

“I withdrew from worldly societies, and even secluded myself from my own kin. My belief was that if I could not be affected by anyone, I would stay pure to my belief. But the world came after me unbidden, seeking to plunder, to ravish my body, and to claim what I had built with my own two hands… Do you understand, Elmer? I do not care what anyone does out there. I do not judge. But if you intrude my sanctuary, I will not hesitate to show you the true meaning of evil in every sense of the word.”

I could not have said anything even if I wanted to. After all, we were the ones at fault. Kyle had gotten off quick, and I was paying the remaining balance for his folly. It was understandable, but it did not make it any more bearable.

Feonna walked back and sat again. She looked at me carefully, as if she wanted to assess something before she spoke.

“You are different,” she said after a while. “You remind me of my young self. The version of me that I hate so completely that I would rather die than live as her. This world… and yours, they don’t have a place for people like you. There are only two choices life offers you. Turn bad to adapt, or become strong enough that no one messes with you.”

I met her gaze without fear for the first time.

“I am not strong. I don’t think I will ever be. The version of me that accepts wrong ideals to adapt is the version of me that I hate so completely that I would rather die than live as him.”

Feonna straightened. For a long moment she stared at me, and I saw something pass behind her eyes, a bright, dangerous spark. She walked towards the table and placed a cold palm on my cheek. Her expression softened into a tender smile.

“I think,” she said, “that I shall keep you.”

***

I did not know how long the experiments lasted. Two weeks, perhaps. When they ended, it was quietly, without ceremony, as if she had simply finished a book and set it on a shelf.

I left the table for the first time, and I sat in one corner of the study like a rat with nowhere else to go. Maitah brought me some simple linen clothes. She healed what could be healed using strange potions and the vampire's blood. She brought porridge and meat. My digestive system had been locked for so long that I grew severely sick after I ate. Then again Maitah worked her magic and I either recovered or believed I had recovered.

Feonna came to inspect me casually in the days that followed, and during one of her visits, she produced a collar.

It was a thin band of dark leather, soft as skin, with a ring of tarnished silver at the throat. She fastened it around my neck herself, tugging the buckle snug, and from her sleeve she drew a long silver chain. It clicked into the ring with a sound I will hear in my sleep for the rest of my life.

"There," she said, stepping back. "Much better."

"I'm not a dog," I managed.

"Not quite. You are a pet." Her smile was almost tender. "Pets are loved, Elmer. They are fed. They are kept warm. Do you know how many in this world can say the same?"

I should have hated her. For a while I tried. But hatred is a heavy thing to carry when you are hungry and weak, and Feonna had a way of making it seem like effort wasted on bad weather.

She took me everywhere. I trailed behind her through the castle's endless halls, the chain looped around her wrist, my bare feet whispering across carpets deeper than anything I had known on Earth. I never saw anyone else besides Maitah. There were rooms with ceilings painted like night skies. A library that stretched on for what might have been miles. She even had a conservatory where white flowers bloomed in the dark, and Feonna crouched among them, humming, her fingertips brushing the petals.

She fed me from her own table. She had a chair brought for me by the fire and set my chain on the arm of her own. In the evenings, she sat in her plush sofa in the library and read quietly, and I would sit by her feet until she was done.

It was the quiet that frightened me most. Not the cruelty, not the blood, but how little it would take to forget. To *adapt*. One night, as the fire sank to embers, she stroked my hair, absentmindedly, the way one pets a cat, and said, "Tell me about your world."

I stiffened. "Why? You already saw what's in my mind."

"I am curious." Her fingers paused. "And reading minds does not reveal everything. I want to know more."

I told her things. The cities. The energy spheres that protected our cities from the Avarrai. The academy. The levels. The boards. The way we had come to Elsewhere hungry and desperate and ready to kill anything that bled.

She listened attentively, never interrupting unless she wanted more context on something. I noticed our means of transport caught her interest right away, especially airplanes and submarines. I barely knew anything about how they operated, and I could tell that Feonna was mildly disappointed when I could not elaborate more on their mechanisms. By the time I was done, she had forgotten about her book, and she stared at a wall dreamily, her hand unmoving on top of my head.

“I think,” she said at last, “I would like to see your world.”

# Chapter Twelve: A Rescue Party

~

I was eventually given a room to stay in, having spent a lot of nights sleeping in one corner in the study. The room had apparently belonged to the late vampire. There were more wardrobes, beauty accessories and mirrors than I cared to count, but in the end I was just grateful for getting a warm bed.

Maitah brought me food. Feonna came to fetch me whenever she felt like it. I was unguarded. Even if I had some funny ideas – I did not – I would need some provisions if I were to survive outside the castle. Unlike the vampires, I did not have a long lifespan and eternal youth. Soon I would wither into a pathetic old man. Feonna would discard me. I would die alone in the desolate, frozen plains as a failed cadet. The world would move on.

My door swung open. I had been sitting on the edge of the bed, wondering if I would have the stomach to kill if the chance presented itself again. Feonna walked in, sparing a casual look at the late vampire's wall portrait. Her eyes quickly lost interest and drifted towards me.

"I may not be able to see you for a few days," she said. She closed her mouth, then opened it again. Then she fell silent.

"Where are you going?" I asked, though I was certain I did not want to know.

"I shall sleep," Feonna said after some time. She sounded very tired and older than I had ever heard her. "It will be a few days. Perhaps more. There are things I must think on, and the thinking is best done in dreams." She reached out for the chain, which never quite left my collar. In a way, it had become a uniform I wore to please her. I shunned it, but I had no say in the matter. "You will keep me company until I wake up."

Her bedchamber occupied the highest tower of the castle.

It was a circular room, almost as vast as the dining hall back at the base, hung with silk the color of dried roses. There was a single vast window on the far wall, and a great round skylight of colored glass through which the winter stars burned in broken pieces. In the center stood a bed so large it could have held a dozen people, its posts carved from black wood into the shapes of climbing vines.

Feonna fastened the end of my chain around the nearest bedpost. She ran her thumb along the link, as if testing a knot, and then, almost shyly, she patted my head.

"Be good," she said.

She lay down. She did not undress, or even remove her slippers. She simply stretched out upon the silks, folded her hands across her stomach, and closed her eyes. The smoke of her gown settled around her like a shroud.

And she stopped.

I mean that exactly. Her chest did not rise. Her skin lost the last trace of warmth. Her face smoothed into something perfect and distant, like the effigy on a tomb. If I had not watched her lie down, I would have thought she'd been dead a century.

I sat at the foot of the bed with my back against the post and listened to the silence.

The first night, I watched the images and maps that were pinned to the walls. The second night, I tried to read a book on Feonna's nightstand with no success. The third night, I simply sat, staring at the terrifying woman on the bed, trying to understand what I felt.

Maitah came twice a day with a tray of food. During those times, she would unfasten my chain for my bathroom break. I had never understood *what* she was. On some days she looked like a normal person. On others, she resembled Feonna. On the third night visit, I took a gamble.

I grabbed her hand as she fastened the chain to the bedpost, as gently as I could. Her skin was warm. She stared at my hand, a flicker of surprise flashing across her face.

"I cannot answer all those questions," she said before I even uttered a word. "You will not die anytime soon, that's all I can tell you."

"Please," I begged, "at least explain to me what my future holds. Is this how I will live until your Mistress grows tired of seeing me?"

Maitah glanced at the bed, then at the door.

"Will it do you any good if I tell you that the Mistress can see into a person's future when she reaches into their mind? She saw something in you. I do not know what, but it ties your existence to hers. She has tried to come to terms with it in the past few days, but... The Mistress only sleeps when she feels troubled, and you, Elmer, are the source of her troubles." She pulled free. "Eat. Please. And do not speak of this again."

She left. I ate, because there was nothing else to do.

On the fifth night, I heard some screaming.

***

It began far below, so faint that at first I took it for wind. A high, thin sound, rising and falling. Then another voice joined it, deeper, ragged. Then the clash of steel against something that was not steel, and a roar that shook dust from the rafters.

I scrambled to my feet. The chain snapped taut against my collar.

“Feonna,” I hissed. “Feonna, wake up!”

She did not stir.

The noise rose. The floor trembled with distant footsteps, a lot of running feet. I heard doors splintering. I heard a woman’s voice, thin and desperate, calling for help, and then not calling for anything at all. Somewhere below, a bell began to ring, a harsh, brazen clangor that rolled up through the stone.

I had never been so afraid of a rescue. It came closer. Boot heels thundering up the winding stair. A burst of laser fire, the crack and whine I’d carried on my back for half a year. A man’s voice, shouting orders in the flat, practiced cadence of the academy.

“Floor’s clear! Move, move!”

The tower door exploded inward.

Six figures spilled into the room. They wore the gray jackets of the cadet corps, and their weapons were nothing I’d been issued: long, humming rifles, curved blades that glowed faintly red. They carried themselves like soldiers, not students. Their eyes swept the room, the dead woman on the bed, the rose-colored silks, the skylight scattered with stars, and at last, they found me.

“There!” someone cried. “Don’t shoot, he might be one of ours!”

A broad-shouldered figure pushed through the others, rifle slung, helmet clasped in one hand. He was larger than I remembered. Harder. A new scar split his chin, and his jacket was torn at the shoulder. But I would have known that face anywhere.

“Elmer?” Jimmy whispered. “*Elmer*?”

“Jimmy.” My voice broke. “Jimmy, it’s me. It’s really me.”

He crossed the room in huge strides and dropped to his knees in front of me. His hands were shaking as he took my face between them, turning it to the light, and I saw his eyes were bright.

“We thought you were dead,” he said. “Everyone said you’d gone north with that assassin. Nobody came back. I shouldn’t have let Lex...” His thumb brushed my cheek, and I realized I was crying. “Hold on. Hold still. I’ve got you.”

He seized the chain and began working at the collar with a thin, silver-bladed dagger. Behind him, I heard the others fanning out, boots creaking across the floor.

“That’s the target,” a woman’s voice said, hard and eager. “The vampire. She must be hibernating.”

“Do it fast,” said another. “Before she wakes.”

“She won’t wake. Look at her skin. She’s dormant.”

“Kill her anyway. Stakes at her chest, blades at her throat. Whatever she’s got, it’s *ours.*”

“Jimmy,” I whispered. My heart had started to pound. “Jimmy, don’t let them near her.”

“Don’t worry. We’ll end her.” He didn’t look up. The collar snapped, and the chain slid off me with a gradual motion that made it appear sentient. “There. Now we just need to...”

“No,” I said. “You don’t understand. Jimmy, she’s...”

Someone chuckled softly.

It was a sleepy, contented sound, the sound of someone stretching beneath warm sheets. All six cadets froze.

I looked up.

Feonna lay exactly as she had lain for five days, hands folded, eyes closed. But the corner of her mouth had curved upward, very slightly. And then, before any of us could draw breath, her violet eyes opened.

Something wet struck my face.

I thought it was rain. For a moment, I honestly thought the skylight had broken, and the storm had come through. Warm drops pattered across my cheeks, my arms, the silks. It came faster, a drumming downpour, and the air filled with a coppery sweetness.

Red. All of it red.

I wiped my eyes and looked up. Feonna stood at the foot of the bed, yawning delicately behind one hand, her smoky gown curling around her ankles. In her other hand, she held something by the hair.

It was Jimmy’s head.

# Chapter Thirteen: Free to Go

~

Rain does not stop when it falls from a person.

It kept coming for a few seconds longer, thinning to a patter, then to slow, heavy drops from the silk canopy. Six bodies lay where they had fallen, their rifles still humming faintly on the floorboards. None of them had made a sound. I had seen Feonna in a confrontation once, in the great hall, and I had thought I understood. I hadn't. That time she had killed one man. This time she had killed six, in less time than it takes to draw a breath, and she was yawning.

"Honestly," she said, in a voice thick with sleep. "In my bedroom."

She held Jimmy's head at arm's length, wrinkling her nose. Blood ran down her wrist and soaked into the sleeve of her gown, and the smoke drank it, swirling darker for a moment before turning black again.

"Do you know how long it takes to get this out of silk?" she said to no one. Then her eyes found me. "Friends of yours?"

I knelt where Jimmy had left me, and I did not answer. I could not. The man who had worked the collar open was a heap of broken things on the floor, and the thing she held was not him. It was not him. His eyes were half open. His mouth was slightly parted, as if he'd been about to say *hold on*.

He had been so sure he could save me.

The sound that came out of me was not a word. I put my hands over my face, and my shoulders shook. I thought of the lunchroom table with the crooked leg. I thought of him wedging a folded napkin beneath it every morning, because it bothered him when things wobbled. I thought of him taking Lex's side, and of how I had argued, and of how he had come anyway.

Above me, Feonna was silent.

When I finally looked up, she was watching me. The boredom had left her face, and in its place was something I hadn't seen before. It was not pity. It was closer to puzzlement, the look of someone who has stepped on a flower and cannot understand why it makes a sound.

She set Jimmy's head down on the silk, gently, almost respectfully.

"Maitah," she called, not loudly. "I shall bathe. Bring the oils. And have someone see to the floor."

The servant appeared in the doorway at once, as though she had never left. Her amethyst dress was stained to the hem with blood. Her face was gray. She did not look at the bodies.

“Yes, Mistress.”

Feonna swept past me, trailing smoke and the scent of old wine. At the door, she paused without turning.

“Stay here,” she said.

***

I stayed.

I do not know how long. The candles did not burn down. The blood dried tacky on my face and neck, and the room slowly filled with the quiet sounds of servants. For the first time, I saw the other inhabitants of the castle. They were people, or had once been people. They were too pale, five maidens who had the same uniform as Maitah’s, their dark hair so long it brushed past their waists.

The maidens cleaned quietly, lifting, wrapping, carrying. Someone pressed a damp cloth into my hands, and I did not use it. When they came for Jimmy, I stood up, and one of them shook her head very slightly, and I sat down again.

When Feonna returned, her hair was wet and loose, and she wore a robe of pale gray silk that looked like frost. She smelled of lavender. She might have been any aristocrat in the world, fresh from her bath, except that her feet were bare and left no prints on the floor.

She sat on the edge of the bed. She studied me for a long while, and her fingers drummed once against her knee.

“You are grieving,” she said at last.

I said nothing.

“It is a strange thing to watch. I have seen it before, naturally. A mother over a child. A man over a wife. But I had not expected it from you.” She tilted her head. “You don’t agree with what they do. And yet you weep for this one.”

“He was my friend,” I said hoarsely.

“Yes. I rather thought so.” Another pause. “Do you wish to go back to your people?”

I thought I had misheard her.

“I do not mean to the mountain,” she said. “I mean to the place with the sun and the glass buildings, and the weak little spheres that hum.” Her lip curved. “To the place that made you.”

“You would let me?”

“My home has been compromised. Your people know where I live now. I will not run or hide. I will exterminate each and every one of them until they realize their efforts are futile. I would hate it if I ended up killing you by accident… or on purpose.”

Feonna did not bluff, which made it difficult to believe that she would let me go with no conditions.

“If you wish to stay, I will not force you to leave,” she faltered then. “I find I tolerate your presence more than I should, but the decision is completely yours. What do you want, Elmer?”

It should have been easy for me to choose leaving. Part of me hated Feonna for what she had done to me. A part of me would never forget the horrors she had subjected me to. Then why did it feel like I would lose something by leaving this cursed castle*? Was my mind under Maitah’s influence?*

“I want to go home.”

Feonna looked at me for a long moment. It seemed she had expected a different response, but her face betrayed no surprise.

“Then go.”

I stared at her.

“I will not stop you,” she said. “No one in this castle will touch you. Maitah will see you to the gate.” She smiled, thin and sweet. “But I have a hunch you will regret your choice.”

I remained silent, not certain whether I or not to feel grateful. Feonna rose and walked to the window, where the skylight scattered the dawn into colors across her face. When she spoke again, her voice had changed, quieter and colder than I had ever heard it. “Hear me, Elmer. Take this with you, and carry it to whoever shall command you henceforth. Anyone who comes to disturb my peace will meet the same fate as those who came before. *Anyone.*”

She did not need to remind me. I would never forget the nightmare of her existence even if I wanted to.

“Do you understand?”

“I understand.”

“Good.” She turned her head, and her smile returned, soft and faintly mocking. “Run along, pet.”

***

Maitah led me down through the castle. My rifle had been returned to me, along with a carefully packed bag of rations.

We passed the gallery of portraits. We passed a stair where a cadet's glove lay in a corner, forgotten. We passed the great hall. The marble had been scrubbed clean, and Kyle's body was gone, and not a trace of gray dust remained. Maitah said nothing, and I said nothing, and at the great doors she stopped and pressed something small into my palm. It was cold and flat. A badge.

"I retrieved it from the human you came with. I thought someone ought to carry it home."

"Thank you," I whispered.

"Go." Her eyes were sad. "Go quickly. Before she changes her mind."

The doors opened onto the snow. I walked outside, looking back once after a few yards. The doors were closing, but I managed to see Maitah's face one last time. Something about her expression told me she already knew what awaited me in the unknown.

***

I walked for a week.

I will not tell you all of it. The path south was the one Kyle had led me up. A lot had changed since then. Snow had fallen, and I could barely identify the landscape. I walked until my feet throbbed. I slept in hollows and ate in silence, and every night I lay awake, listening for footsteps behind me.

None came.

That frightened me most of all. I had spent weeks in her company, and I knew her well enough to be sure of one thing. She did not do anything without reason. She had let me go. She had handed me my weapons. She had warned me, and then, with a smile, she had sent me back to the people who had provoked her wrath twice.

It was a trap. It had to be. Maybe she had set something on my trail, a thing that crawled in shadows, a hound that would wait until I reached the base. Maybe she wanted me to lead her there. Maybe, even now, she was watching through the eyes of some bird in the trees, laughing softly to herself.

But what could I do? Stay in the snow and die? Wander until I was found by a hunting party who would see only a level twelve, with a badge and a story no one would believe?

I had no choice. I walked.

I was on the verge of madness and starvation when the landscape started to look familiar. Not long afterwards, a portal appeared ahead, a pale blue oval shimmering against the dawn. Beyond it lay Earth-hollow, and beyond that the rift, and the base, and the academy, and the boards with their cheerful offers. I stood at its edge for a long time with the wind tugging at my sleeves. Then I stepped through the portal.

# Chapter Fourteen: Stuck

~

The registry console blinked at me for a long time before it admitted I was still alive.

*Cadet Elmer Leich, Level 12. Status: Active. Last check-in: 51 days ago.*

Fifty-one days. I stared at the number until the clerk behind the glass cleared his throat and asked if I intended to move. I scanned my badge a second time to make sure it wasn't a mistake, then walked into the base with Kyle's badge heavy in my pocket and the smell of boiled cabbage turning my stomach.

Nobody looked twice at me. I don't know why I had expected a hero's return welcome. I did not even get the curious stares. Instead, cadets flowed past with trays and rifles, and the board in the hall announced a special on goblin shamans, and the world went on as though no one had ever been gone.

I found Lex in the training yard.

He was practicing alone at the far range, a laser rifle braced against his shoulder, firing at paper targets that burned through before the smoke had cleared. Each shot hit the same spot. I watched him fire a whole magazine without a single miss, and I thought, *that is what killing children gets you.*

He lowered the rifle before I spoke. He must have heard me coming.

"You're alive," Lex said.

"Why wouldn't I be?"

He turned. His face had thinned and hardened, but his eyes were the same. For a moment, we just stood there with the target range humming between us.

"We thought you were dead," he said. "Jimmy swore you were. He went north to look for you, Elmer. He wouldn't wait for me." His voice cracked on the last word. "Where is he? Did he find you? He left with a raid party three weeks ago and nobody's heard from..."

I had rehearsed this on the long walk south. I had never found the words.

"Lex," I said. "He's gone."

It took a moment to arrive. I watched it cross his face in stages, confusion, denial, then something raw underneath. He set the rifle down on the bench with enormous care, the way you put down something that might break.

“How?”

I told him everything. I told it flat and plain, because anything else would have sounded wrong. The assassin. The castle in the snow. The woman with violet eyes who had pulled out a man’s heart with her bare hand. I told him about the chain and the collar, though I skipped the worst of the study. I told him about the second raid, and how Jimmy had knelt in front of me and assured me we were going to make it out. How he had died immediately afterwards.

When I finished, Lex was sitting on the bench with his head in his hands.

“He was my cousin,” he said into his palms. “He came here for me. He wasn’t even a fighter, he just...” His shoulders shook once, hard. Then he went still. “And you walked out. They let you walk out.”

“She let me walk out. It might be a trap. I don’t know.”

“A vampire let you go.” He lifted his head. His eyes were red, but there was something else behind the grief, something I’d seen before, at the well. “Do you hear how that sounds?”

“I know how it sounds.”

“Well, it’s not like I can do anything even if you’re lying.” He drew a ragged breath. “If you haven’t changed, I’ll take your word for it.”

We sat in silence for a while. Across the yard, a cadet laughed at something. A target fell and burned.

“I joined Marysse’s party,” Lex said at last.

I looked at him.

“Level thirty-six now, she is. The most wonderful healer I know. She said yes when I asked.” He rubbed his face. “I thought I’d feel different. Happy. I keep waiting to.” He glanced at me, unsure. “I’m sorry about the village. About what I said. It’s this bloody world, Elmer. We have to look out for each other, as difficult as it seems. We have room in the party. A fifth slot. I could carry you to forty in a month, and you’d have a healer at your back.”

It was the offer I would have killed for a month ago. A real party. A healer. A way out of level thirteen.

I thought of the girl running through the trees. I thought of her eyes. Her soft, frightened laughter.

“No,” I said.

“Elmer.”

“I can’t, Lex. You know I can’t. I’d be standing next to you every time.”

“You’ll be stuck.” His voice rose. “Do you understand? No party, no healer, no chance. The villages aren’t what they were. They’ve fortified them. Elven mages, wards, traps that drop a whole squad before they even see the walls. Two parties got wiped last week. They go for the healers first. Marysse has nearly died twice.”

“That seems like a you-problem.”

“Don’t be stubborn. How will you hunt without a team?”

“I’d rather be stuck here for ages than do whatever it is you do to poor villagers.”

He stared at me, jaw working. I watched him decide whether to argue, and then, gradually, I watched him stop. He picked up his rifle and turned away.

“Don’t die,” he said, over his shoulder. “At least do that for Jimmy.”

I had a sure way to do that. I was done. Feonna, though evil beyond what I could possibly comprehend, had given me another chance to go home. I was not going to waste it. If I could help, I would do so in another way.

I went to the gate officer that evening and asked to leave. I meant Earth, not Elsewhere. I wanted to go to the academy’s registration office and officially resign. I’d find some work to pay for a ride home, if home still existed at all.

“Below sixty? No.”

“I’ve served for months in the field. Am I not allowed to return?”

“That’s not a rank.” He turned a page. “Cadets under sixty don’t pass back through the rifts. Terms were updated ages ago, or did you not read what you signed?”

I was pretty sure I had read most of it, and not once had I stumbled upon anything resembling what he was saying.

“The portals to go back to earth use real electricity, in case you’ve forgotten. And we don’t run on infinite sources. Can’t have nobodies wasting resources, otherwise this would be a vacation for you lot. Level up or stay where you are.”

“What if I *can’t* level?”

“Then you’ll have a long, long career.” He finally looked at me. “And for your sake I hope you’re cabbage-tolerant.”

There was nothing I could do then. There was no going back. The only door home led through sixty levels of blood, and the only way to walk through it was alone.

I spent the night preparing. Rations for a week, packed tight. Two flasks. A fire kit, a knife, spare power cells. I pinned Kyle's badge on the bed beside my own and stared at them for a long time, then pinned them both to the inside of my jacket where no one could see.

I would reach sixty. I would go home. I would never come back.

I told myself that as the portal swallowed me the next morning, and I told myself again as the blue light spat me out into a gold and silent forest.

I walked all day and nothing happened. Not an ambush, not a stray orc. I did not even meet any party of fellow cadets. The trees and the birds and the sunlight all behaved as though I wasn't there. I climbed ridges and crossed streams, scanning for movement. I found a few forsaken villages. Most had been veiled by magic, and at times I could feel that someone was near, though I could neither see nor hear them.

By the time the sun slipped down toward the treetops, my feet ached and my temper had worn thin. I sat on a rock, kicked a pebble into the undergrowth, and stared at the sky. A whole day, and I hadn't earned an ounce of experience.

A strange wind blew through the forest floor. With it came a strange sound. It was soft, wandering, a tune with no beginning and no end. It drifted through the trees from somewhere ahead, high and sweet and slightly out of key.

At first, I assumed the wind was passing through a crack in a tree, but trees did not have rhythm. I rose slowly, rifle in hand, and crept toward it.

At the edge of a mossy clearing, in the last amber light of the day, a creature knelt among the toadstools. She was no taller than my waist. Gauzy wings, thin as dragonfly glass, trembled on her back, catching the light in streaks of kaleidoscopic colors. A small wicker basket sat at her knee, half-filled with pale grey and orange mushrooms. She picked them one at a time, humming as she worked, her gold hair spilling down around her in curls so long they pooled on the ground.

I knew what she was. The scouters had labelled them special and rare, granting unknown experience value. *Fey.*

I primed my rifle.

The sight settled on her small, slender back. My finger found the trigger. The hum didn't stop. She had no idea. *One shot*. I had never felt so thrilled.

# Chapter Fifteen: A Fairy Named Nyx

~

I stood still, my finger feeling numb. It would have been simple. I had killed goblins that looked more dangerous than she did. But the humming went on, slow and sweet and unaware, and I thought of a small hand around a wooden horse.

The silence must have lasted a second too long. The humming stopped. Her wings went rigid. Slowly, like a deer that had caught a scent on the wind, she turned her head.

She was not what I expected. From behind, I had taken her for a child. But the face that looked back at me was a woman's, young and startlingly lovely, with wide gray-green eyes, a small mouth, and a spray of freckles across her nose. Her golden hair fell to her knees in heavy curls. She was frozen with a mushroom in one hand, staring at the barrel of my rifle.

The basket tipped from her knee and spilled across the moss.

"Please," she whispered. Her voice was low and frightened. "Please don't. I have nothing. I'm nobody. Please, please don't kill me."

I should have fired. Every rule I had learned in six months told me to fire. But her wings were shaking so hard, and she had clasped her hands under her chin like a child begging for a sweet.

I lowered the rifle an inch. If I let her go, she would likely notify her kind of my presence. I would not be so confident against an army of fairies.

"I won't." She shook her head wildly, curls swinging. "I can't. There's no one. My kind are gone, all of them, long ago. There's only me." She said it in a rush, and I realized, with a prickle on the back of my neck, that I had not spoken anything yet. "I wouldn't know who to bring."

"Get out of my head."

"I only hear it when it's loud." Her eyes flicked to the rifle and away, as if the sight of it burned. "Please, I'll give you anything. I have a home. It's safe. I could give you a bed and hot food. Real food. Just... please point that somewhere else."

It was absurd. A creature less than half my size, bargaining for her life with soup. And yet I felt my stomach clench with hunger at the word. My rations were mostly the toothpaste stuff, and it had a habit of chasing away an appetite one you saw it. I thought of the last thing that had hunted me in the dark, that enormous hillock opening its amber eye, and I thought of the night coming down.

This was a gamble. Fairies were tricksters, if stories were to be believed. I had to keep my guard up, but better a troublesome fairy than a humongous night monster.

“Show me,” I said. I pointed the rifle downwards.

She let out a shaky breath. “Thank you. Thank you.”

I kept my rifle ready by my side. The fairy gathered her mushrooms with trembling hands, and we went.

***

She flew low, just ahead of me, her wings blurring into a faint violet haze. The forest thickened. The trail dwindled to deer paths, then to nothing, and twice she stopped and turned in a circle as if reading a map only she could see. At last the trees opened onto a sheer gray cliff, its face draped in ivy and thorns.

She hovered before it and waved her hand.

The ivy shivered. The stone seemed to ripple like water, and where it had been solid, a dark slit opened, narrow and tall, shaped like a half-open vertical mouth.

“Almost there.” Her smile was shy. “Mind your head.”

The passage was barely taller than I was. It twisted and narrowed, and in places I had to unstrap my pack to turn sideways, scraping my shoulders against the rock. Her wings lit the way, glowing a bright, steady violet that threw our shadows long against the walls. I lost count of the bends. The air grew cool and damp and smelled of stone and herbs. Once I stopped, my pack wedged in a crack, and she giggled, a sudden bright sound that startled us both.

“Sorry,” she said, hand over her mouth. “The passage is not used to big people.”

At last the tunnel ended at a round stone door, shorter than me but wide enough to squeeze through. She pushed it with one hand, and it swung inward on silent hinges.

I stepped in, stooped, and straightened with my mouth open.

It was a home. Not a burrow, not a den, but a real home. The ceiling arched overhead, studded with blue crystals that glowed like captured moonlight, flooding the room in soft silver. A small hearth stood against one wall, a table and two stools beside it, a rug woven from reeds on the floor. Shelves lined the walls, crowded with jars of dried herbs and tiny carved figures. A curtain of woven grass hung across one doorway, and thin cracks in the ceiling let in a trickle of cool, fresh air, stirring the dried flowers that hung from the rafters.

Everything was small, built for her. But it was tidy. Warm. It looked like somewhere a person had lived on purpose.

“Sit anywhere,” she said. “The floor’s fine.”

I sat. She flitted to the hearth and began stirring the embers back to life, humming again. I watched her back, and the silence stretched until it felt rude.

“I am Nyx, by the way,” she said, without turning.

I said nothing.

“And you are?” she pressed gently.

I hesitated. It felt like handing over a key. “Elmer,” I said at last.

She turned, and her whole face brightened.

“Elmer,” she repeated, testing the word on her tongue. “I like it.”

***

Nyx was good company, which was what unnerved me more than anything. She talked while she cooked, and she listened in a way that made me want to keep talking. When I answered, she leaned toward me with her whole body, and her eyes shone. She asked about the sky on my side, about the cities and the spheres, and weird enough, about our people’s transport systems. I told her about my old home town, where I had left for a chance to save what remained of my people. I told her about the war, and the rifts, and the cadets. I did not tell her about the twins, or about Feonna.

“I don’t like it here anymore,” I said suddenly. It surprised me. “In Elsewhere. I don’t think I’ve liked it for a while. If there were a way to go home, I’d take it.”

Nyx’s hands paused over the pot. Her expression softened into something so naked and sad that I looked away.

“I know,” she said quietly. “I could hear it.”

She set a bowl in front of me, and the smell reached me before I could speak.

Rabbit stew, thick with mushrooms, the broth golden and rich, a hunk of warm bread beside it, still steaming. I ate the first spoonful and closed my eyes. I had eaten Maitah’s bland cooking for so long that it had started to taste good. This reminded me what real food tasted like.

“This is the best meal I’ve had in this world,” I said.

Nyx went pink to the tips of her ears. “Oh... It’s only stew.”

“It’s not only stew.”

“Well.” She fidgeted with her sleeve, eyes lowered, a smile tugging at her mouth. “You can have more.”

I ate three bowls. When I finally set down my spoon, my body felt heavy and warm, as though someone had wrapped me in blankets from the inside. She brought out a small stoneware jug and two thimble-sized cups, and poured something amber and glittering.

“Honey wine,” she said. “I make it myself. For special occasions.” She slid a cup toward me with both hands.

“I wouldn’t call this special,” I chuckled. “To your hospitality,” I added, and drank.

It was sweet, and strong, and faintly floral. I drank it down in a single swallow and held out the cup for more.

Then the room tilted.

It was gentle at first, a slow slide, like the first moment of falling asleep in a moving car. The blue crystals smeared into long streaks. I blinked, and my eyelids felt like lead. I tried to say something, and my tongue would not shape the words.

Across the table, Nyx watched me. She was still smiling. But her eyes had changed, and in the last clear second, I saw something behind them, careful and bright and terribly hopeful, like a child watching a butterfly settle in a jar.

“Don’t worry,” she whispered. “You’ll be safe.”

The floor rose to meet me.

# Chapter Sixteen: A Good Guest

~

I woke to the smell of petals and the feeling of being very small.

It took me a moment to understand why. My cheek was pressed against cold stone. My arms were pulled behind me, and my legs had been folded and drawn together. Something thin and rough was wrapped around my wrists, my ankles, my chest, binding me upright against the corner of the room.

I jerked, and it tightened.

Vines. Slender green vines, dotted with tiny white buds, wound around my body like a living net. I tried to tear at them, and they pulsed, flexing against my skin as if they could feel me struggling. When I stopped, they loosened a little. When I moved, they squeezed.

I forced myself to breathe. The room looked just as it had the night before. Blue crystals glowed overhead. The hearth had burned down to a few warm coals. The tiny table stood in its place, the stools tucked neatly under it, as if nothing had happened. But my rifle was gone. My knife was gone. My pack was gone. My jacket had been unbuckled, and the two badges that had been pinned inside lay on the table, neatly aligned, side by side.

I was alone.

"Nyx!" My voice came out cracked. "Nyx!"

Silence. The crack in the ceiling let in a thin thread of cold air.

I pulled against the vines until sweat ran down my face, and all I gained was a purple ring around each wrist. Somewhere inside the mountain, water dripped. I counted the drips and lost count. I told myself that I should have known. Wine from a stranger. A cave hidden behind an illusion. A woman who could read my mind.

*Stupid,* I thought. *You are so stupid.*

***

The stone door swung open an hour later.

Nyx flitted in with a wicker basket on her arm, humming a cheerful, off-key tune, her wings glittering in the crystal light. The basket was filled with wild herbs and tiny red berries. Her curls were tied up loosely with a bit of blue ribbon, and there were streaks of mud on her bare knees, as though she had been crawling through a garden.

She saw me, and her face broke into a smile.

“Good morning!”

“Let me go.”

“Did you sleep well? I wasn’t sure about the wine. I measured it very carefully, but you’re so big, and I never know...”

“Nyx.” I leaned forward against the vines. They bit into my arms. “I’m going to say this once. Let me go right now, or I swear...”

“Or what?” She tilted her head, genuinely curious.

“I’ll make you regret it. I’ll burn this place down. I’ll find your people, whatever’s left of them, and I’ll...”

“You won’t,” she said simply.

The words were not defiant. In fact, they sounded kind. She set her basket on the table, and she did not so much as glance at the rifle I could see leaning against the far wall, well out of my reach.

“You are my guest,” she said. “I would never hurt a guest. And a guest would never hurt me. That’s how it works.”

“I’m tied up!”

“For your safety.”

“My safety?”

She only smiled.

I stared at her, and a chill ran down my back. It was not the vines, or the stone, or even the thought of what she could do to me. It was her face. There was no cruelty in it. No malice. She looked at me the way a girl looks at a puppy she has found in the rain.

“When will you let me go?” I said, more quietly.

She didn’t answer. She hummed instead, and busied herself at the hearth.

***

Breakfast was warm oatcakes, honey, and a bowl of the little red berries, still shining with water. She set it down in front of me, deliberately, just barely within my reach. She sat on the other side of the room with her own bowl and began to eat, swinging her legs.

“Aren’t you hungry?” she asked.

“No.”

“You must be.”

“I’m not eating anything you give me.”

“It isn’t poisoned.” She sounded hurt. “I’d never. The wine only made you sleepy. If you keep drinking it, you’ll end up *not* sleeping from it at all.”

“Is that so?”

“It’s the truth.” She picked a berry from her bowl, popped it into her mouth, and showed me the stem. “See? Safe. I’d never hurt my guest.”

I looked away.

When she had finished, she cleared the dishes, hummed, flitted around the room, and eventually disappeared through the woven grass curtain. I heard splashing. Soft singing. Water running over stone. I fixed my eyes on the ceiling and tried to loosen the vines by inches, a fraction at a time. Every time I moved, they tightened in answer.

She was gone a long time. When she returned, she hovered in the curtain’s opening and clasped her hands behind her.

“Well?” she said. “How do I look?”

She had changed. The mud and the muddy dress were gone, and in their place was a gown of pale green, stitched with tiny silver leaves, its skirt flaring around her knees. Her hair was loose, brushed until it shone, with a crown of white flowers pinned above her brow. She turned in a slow circle in midair, wings flickering, and looked at me with such open hope that the words I’d been about to say dried up in my mouth.

She was not trying to be clever, I realized. She was not testing me, or manipulating me, or putting on a show. She had simply not had anyone to ask in a very long time.

I swallowed my pride.

“You look nice,” I said.

“Really?”

“Really. The flowers are... very good.”

Her face lit up. A blush crept across her cheeks, and she pressed both hands to them, fluttering back to earth with a giddy little laugh. “Thank you! I picked them this morning. I wasn’t sure about the white, but white is such a hopeful color, don’t you think?”

“It suits you,” I said, because it seemed to be the right thing to say.

She beamed at me, then bounced away to stir the stew.

And I sat there in my vines and thought, with a strange, helpless horror, *she’s not dangerous. She’s lonely.* And somehow that made my situation much worse.

***

By nightfall, my limbs had gone numb.

She cooked another supper, a creamy soup with leeks and barley, and set it down in the same place. I still refused it. She didn’t push. She ate her own with a patient little sigh, and every so often I felt her watching me with those wide gray-green eyes.

I held out as long as I could. Finally, with a growing sense of humiliation, I cleared my throat.

“I need to use the bathroom.”

She froze with her spoon halfway to her mouth.

For a long moment, the only sound was the faint crackle of the fire. She looked at me. She looked at the vines. I watched the question cross her face in a dozen shades, hope and fear and calculation, as childish as a game of pretend.

“Do you promise,” she said slowly, “not to hurt me?”

“I promise.”

“And that you won’t run away after?”

I met her gaze. I thought of the door, of the long twisting passage, of the rifle against the wall. I thought of how small she was. One solid kick would break a dozen bones. Just a moment to maneuver, and I would end these shenanigans.

“I promise,” I said. “I won’t leave.”

She studied me for a long time. Then she lifted one finger, as lightly as a conductor beginning a song, and flicked it.

The vines sighed away.

They slid from my wrists and my ankles like snakes, curling back toward the corner, and the blood rushed into my hands so fast it hurt. I fell on my side and caught myself at the last moment. Nyx was at my shoulder at once, hovering anxiously. She gestured at the curtain.

“It’s through there. There’s clean water too. There’s a bucket, and a bit of soap... You can use my towel if you want… it’s small though.” She wrung her hands. “You won’t be long, will you?”

That made me hesitate.

“No.”

“You promised.”

I looked at her and forced a smile. “I know.”

I stumbled through the grass curtain into a small, steamy chamber with a stone basin and a trickling spring. On the other end was what I assumed to be the toilet, shaped much like our own seats but made out of hard grey clay. Everything was spotless. A neatly folded towel lay on a shelf beside a cake of herb-scented soap. I splashed my face, scrubbed the grime off my arms, and stared at my reflection in the dark water. I looked like a man who had been kidnapped by a child.

***

When I went back, Nyx was perched on the edge of the table with her knees drawn up, twisting a lock of golden hair around one finger. The moment she saw me, she lit up like a candle.

“You came back,” she said happily.

“Well, you did make me promise.”

And of course there was no other way out, so I literally had no choice in the matter.

“People say things.” She slid down and hovered in front of me, wings humming. Her eyes were very bright. “I’m so sorry for tying you up. I truly am. I thought... I was afraid you would leave in the morning.”

“Nyx.”

“I didn’t want you to go right away.” The words tumbled out of her faster now. “It’s been so long since anyone came here. You loved my stew, and... I wanted you to try the rest of my cooking.”

“You didn’t have to tie me up,” I mumbled, massaging my wrist reflexively. “You could have just asked.”

Nyx flushed and looked down. “Sorry.”

“I’ll have my food now then,” I said. My stomach echoed with a grumble. “I hope it tastes as good as the rabbit stew.”

Nyx landed on the floor, her face flushed to the roots of her hair.

“It’s even better.”

The fairy busied herself with warming the food. I sat down slowly on the stone floor.

“How long have you stayed here?” I asked.

She paused, then she smiled, and it was the saddest smile I had ever seen.

“Fifty years, give or take,” she said.

I stared at her. At the freckles. At the flowers in her hair. At a face that could not have been a day over twenty. If she was *that* old, there was a chance she had lived in a peaceful Elseworld, long before the academy unleashed packs of power-hungry cadets to burn everything in laser fire.

“Did my people…”

“Yes,” Nyx replied too quickly, wiping her eye with the back of her hand. “Your kind took the only thing that I loved more than myself.”

# Chapter Seventeen: What the Fairy Remembered

~

"Fifty years," I repeated.

Nyx walked over, carrying a tray that had some stew and some water. The blue crystals threw soft light across her face. She looked, for the first time, truly her age, though I still could not have said what that was.

"Fairies don't count the way you do," she said, handing me the tray. "We live long. I was still a girl when the strangers came." She smiled faintly. "I'm still a girl now, I suppose. It's hard to tell."

"Strangers?"

"Your people." She said it without anger. "We lived in the north, in a valley between two mountains. There was no reason to hide back then, and we could handle the few notorious goblins. My family tended a vineyard and a small orchard. I had a sister…Cayle was her name. She was older and better than me in every way. Her songs could make the flowers bloom." Her voice caught, then steadied. "One morning, we saw the strange humans. We were always friendly to humans. We wanted to welcome them… but…"

I said nothing. I could already guess. Nyx sat beside me and crossed her legs.

"We hadn't known what a weapon like that could do. They killed anything that moved, and they made it look so easy. They laughed when my people fell."

There was no word that I could have said that would make it sound less evil than it was. The academy contract stated that cadets underwent combat training by exterminating 'hostile alien natives'. And here, looking down at Nyx, there was nothing that checked that box. She could have slit my throat when I passed out, but here she was, confiding one of her life's darkest moments to one of the strangers who had caused the catastrophe.

"My parents joined the fight to protect our lands. They told us to run as far away as we could, and they promised that they'd find us once everything was back to normal. Cayle took my hand and we ran, north and then east and then anywhere. Any place without the humans with the scary weapons."

"Nyx."

"We hid here." Her eyes drifted across the room, across the shelves and the figurines. "Cayle made this place. Her magic was stronger than mine. She wove the illusion over the door and taught me to make the vines. We thought they'd find us, eventually. And when that didn't happen, we tried to find them." She hugged her arms. "Years passed and we started to assume

the worst. We sought some help from the elves, but not even their best scouters found any trace. After two decades, it seemed that Cayle and I were the only ones who had survived."

I placed a hand gently on her small shoulder, not sure what else I could do.

"They might still be alive," I offered.

"No," Nyx said with a sad smile, wiping her eyes with her fingers. "It just took us a long time to accept. And when we did, the humans took my only source of comfort."

"You don't have to tell me. What my people did was wrong. I want you to know that I will never be like them."

She looked up and met my gaze.

"It's fine. I want you to know. I never told anyone about this before." She hugged her arms again. Her voice dropped into a scared whisper. "She went out one morning to check our traps. A hunting party spotted her, even though she was always careful when and where she moved. She was too far from here." Her shoulders trembled. "I found her three days later. They had clipped her wings as souvenirs. It was hard to accept. It still is. I buried her like she was just a memory, something that was not real. I have waited for her to come back ever since. All this time… I've lived here in hopes that, somehow… she will show up with momma and papa."

Tears streamed down the fairy's face. I let her mourn. She needed it more than she realized. After some time, her shoulders stopped shaking, and her sobs quietened.

"I'm sorry," I said. "I don't know how many times I can say it. I'm sorry."

"It wasn't you."

"It was my people."

"Yes." She lifted her face. Her eyes were wet, her cheeks streaked. "But you didn't shoot me."

I had nothing to answer with. The tears kept running down her face, and she made no effort to hide them. When she spoke again, it was barely a whisper.

"I didn't mean to tie you up. I only wanted..." She searched for the word. "To hear those words again. Cayle used to say them too. She loved my cooking. And I thought… having you would make me feel like I wasn't alone anymore."

I was a very passive person when it came to emotions. For a long time, all I had needed was to be strong enough for myself. But in that moment, my heart beat faster than my mind could think.

I held Nyx by the shoulders, firmly, so that she faced me directly.

“You’ll never be alone again,” I said. And for some reason, I found I meant those words more than anything that I had said in the Elseworld.

We sat for a long time. The fire ticked down to embers. Somewhere in the mountain, water dripped, slow and steady, and a thread of night air stirred the dried flowers overhead.

I could not stop thinking about something. It had troubled me for months, on every patrol, every night in my bunk, every time I watched cadets walk through the portals in laughing groups. It was the sort of question that, once asked, could not be taken back.

“Nyx,” I said carefully. “May I ask something?”

She sniffed and nodded.

“Why haven’t your people closed the portals?”

She blinked.

“The elves, the mages. Everyone. You’re all so strong in magic. You can hide caves behind illusions. You can read minds. I’ve seen enchantments that could stop a whole squad. And yet we keep coming through, in the same places, day after day, and nobody stops us. Why not simply guard the gates? Or seal them? Or...” I trailed off, feeling foolish. “I don’t know. Wouldn’t that end it?”

Nyx stared at me for a moment. Then she gave a small, shaky laugh.

“Do you think we haven’t tried?”

“Haven’t you?”

“Elmer.” She looked at me with something that resembled regret. “We can’t *see* them.”

“What?”

“The portals. The doors.” She gestured vaguely at the air. “None of us can. Not the mages, not the elders, not even the oldest of the high elves. We may have the magic to see the ethers, and yet we cannot sense them, track them, or find them. We don’t know where they are. We don’t know *when* they open.”

I frowned. “So it’s a matter of time displacement.”

“I am not sure. The others say they only ever see you *after*. One moment, there’s an empty field. The next, there are men standing in it, as though they’d been there all along. And when you go home...” She made a vanishing gesture. “You’re simply not there. It’s as if the world forgets you.”

I sat very still.

“It’s the great shame of elven scholars. They’ve spent decades trying to understand it. And every year, more of you arrive, and none of us can stop it, because we can’t even find the lock.”

I thought of the way I stepped through the portal. Of the cold ripple on my skin, and the sense of having crossed from one room to another. To me, it was a door. To them, it was nothing at all.

It made a terrible kind of sense. The Elseworlders were not fighting an army with a front line and supply lines. They were fighting ghosts, enemies who appeared from nowhere and vanished into the same. They could not follow us home. They could not close the entrance. They could only guard the villages and hope.

***

I stayed for the night.

Nyx made soup again, and I ate. When she brought out the little stoneware jug, I put my hand over the cup. She laughed and poured water instead, and we sat by the fire until the embers dimmed.

“Will you stay?” she asked, finally. She tried to say it lightly. “Longer, I mean. I know you can’t. I only wanted to ask.”

I had thought about it for a long time. It was warm and quiet here. I thought of how easy it would be to disappear into this small tidy world and let the war go on without me.

“I can’t,” I said gently. “I’m sorry, Nyx. There are people dying, on both sides. I can’t sit here knowing it.”

She nodded. She had expected it. Her eyes were bright, but she smiled.

“I know. I heard your mind deciding, hours ago. I was hoping I had misheard it.”

“You didn’t hear what I wanted to ask of you.” I shifted to face her squarely. “I don’t know how to start, but I want to find a way to stop this. The killing. All of it. Not just here. I want to save my world too. It’s kind of crazy, trying to kill two birds with one stone. And I am not one of the strong ones…”

“What did you want to ask of me?” Nyx asked, her eyes eager.

“Be my guide. You know this world better than me. I won’t kill innocent souls, that’s all I can promise for now. You can help me level up. Then we find a way to stop my people from emerging *here*.”

She regarded me with a long, serious look, as though weighing something very fragile.

“If I come with you, will you choose me over your own kind?”

“Anyone who tries to harm you will be my enemy, regardless of who they are.”

Nyx looked all around the room, searching for something that she seemed to have forgotten.

“Will I be your servant when I accept your protection?” she asked.

“No,” I said too quickly. “We’ll be equals. Partners.”

Her face filled up with wonder. She stared at me without blinking, pondering. I did not rush her. After all, I was asking her to abandon the safety of her home after knowing her for a single day.

“You won’t threaten me with that thing?” she looked at the laser rifle, which she had placed in the one corner she had avoided all day. I chuckled.

“You will be the one in charge of it, if it makes you feel any better. I will even let you carry it for as long as you want.”

Nyx pouted. “That’s not funny.”

“I will throw it away once I learn good magic,” I negotiated.

The fairy giggled. “Much better. And I will be the one to teach you your first spell, partner.”

# Chapter Eighteen: The Valley Behind the Veil

~

"You said maybe," I muttered, ducking under a low branch. "Maybe they'll kill me."

"I said probably not." Nyx shifted her weight on my left shoulder and ruffled my hair with one hand as if I was her giant puppy. "The *maybe* was an afterthought."

"That's worse."

"It's just honest."

She had climbed up there without asking, the moment we left the cliff, as if it were the most natural thing in the world. Her wings were folded flat, and her legs dangled against my chest. I tried to walk as though nothing were unusual. After an hour, I gave up.

"You're heavy," I said.

"I beg your pardon?"

"I mean you're heavier than you look. It's like carrying a sack of flour."

"A *sack of flour*." She drew herself up with enormous dignity, and her face went pink to the tips of her ears. "I weigh less than a loaf of bread, Mister. Less than a *kitten*."

"A kitten wouldn't make my shoulder hurt."

"I'm not making it hurt, silly." She tugged my collar, scowling, but the corner of her mouth twitched. "It's your shoulder that's bony."

I laughed. I hadn't realized how long it had been since I'd done it.

Nyx had suggested visiting the elves for help. She had promised to put in a good word for me, and I had prayed that would be enough.

The path she led me down was not a path at all. We turned left where there was only brush, and she hummed softly, and the brush parted as if combed. We walked through a gap between two boulders that I would swear had not been there a moment earlier. Once we crossed a stream with no bridge, and on the far bank the forest seemed different, the light greener, the air thick with the scent of cut grass and something sweeter.

"It's a veil," Nyx explained when I asked. "It hides the way. You can only pass if someone who knows the way is with you." She patted my collar. "Don't let go of me."

“I’m not holding you.”

“Then beg me not to fly away.”

***

We reached the hideout by midday.

I had expected a camp, or a fortress, or a ring of spiked walls. What we found was a hillside, covered in ferns, and a hollow oak at its base. Nyx slid off my shoulder, fluttered to the gnarled trunk, and laid her palm against the bark. Then she began to chant.

It was a soft, rising melody, wordless and strange, and as she sang, her wings flared bright purple. The air in front of us rippled like a pond struck by a stone. The hillside seemed to unfold. Ferns peeled apart, the ground sank away, and the world rearranged itself like a picture being turned in the light.

A valley lay beneath us, deep and green and vast, ringed by slopes of silver pine. A river wound through it like a ribbon, and along its banks, nestled in the branches of colossal trees, were houses. Not huts, but elegant homes of pale wood and living leaf, strung together by rope bridges that swung gently in the breeze. Lanterns glimmered in the canopy. Terraced gardens climbed the mountainside. Smoke rose from chimneys, and I could hear, drifting up from below, the unmistakable sound of children laughing.

It was beautiful. It was *peaceful.* It was the sort of place I’d been taught did not exist.

“Welcome,” Nyx said softly, “to Aelindor.”

I did not have time to answer.

A shadow dropped from the oak above us, landing without a sound. The point of a spear touched my throat before I could even flinch.

“Halt,” said a cold voice.

I raised my hands slowly. The elf who held the spear was tall and lean, in forest-green leathers, with a sharp, suspicious face and hair the color of ripe wheat. His ears curved back from his temples like leaves. His eyes were on my uniform. On the jacket.

“A human cadet,” he said, as though the word tasted foul. “In Aelindor.”

“Wait!” Nyx darted between us, flapping furiously. “Wait, he’s with me. He’s a friend.”

“Nyx?” The spear wavered. His eyebrows rose. “You’ve come out of your cave.”

“I had a reason.”

“Did you now?” His voice changed, softened by something I hadn’t expected. “We thought you’d gone. After Cayle...”

“I know.” Nyx’s wings drooped. “I’m sorry. I’m not very good at coming out.” She laid a hand against the spear, and pushed it gently aside. “But please. Trust me. He’s not like the others. I’ve read him.”

The elf’s gaze moved from her face to mine, and I saw the doubt and the pain of an old friendship warring in his eyes.

“You *read* him.”

“All the way down.”

“And?”

“He didn’t shoot me.”

It was a ridiculous answer. It was also, I realized, the only one that mattered. The scout looked at me for a long moment. Then he lowered the spear, and for the first time his expression changed. It was not trust, exactly. It was something warier, and sadder, and more tired.

“If he so much as lifts a finger,” he said to Nyx, “I will not be gentle.”

“He won’t.”

“Come, then.”

We went down a spiral staircase that wound around the trunk of a tree wider than a house. Elves watched us from the bridges and balconies, silent and unreadable. A group of children paused mid-game, wide-eyed, then scattered behind their mothers’ skirts. I kept my hands in plain sight, and my rifle lashed behind my back, and my eyes on the ground.

“They know you?” I whispered to Nyx.

“Some of them, when they helped search for my parents.” She sat on my shoulder again, very quiet. “We used to scout with them. We were here most of the time. They fed us. They are good people.” Her voice dipped. “When she was gone, I couldn’t. I shut the door and stayed inside. I only came when I needed to stock my pantry.”

“And they didn’t come after you?”

“They allowed me to grieve in my own way,” she replied. “They were kind to do so. I didn’t need sympathy.”

The elf, walking ahead, did not turn. But his shoulders eased.

At the foot of the staircase, a wide stone path led to a great hall built into the mountainside, its entrance framed by two carved pillars shaped like intertwined branches. Silver lanterns hung from its arch. Beneath it, two doors of pale wood stood closed, and before them, with a long, slender spear grounded against the floor, stood a single guard.

She was tall. Taller than I was. Her hair fell in a glossy silver curtain to her waist, and her eyes were dark. Her face was severe, finely cut, impossibly elegant, with a stillness that made my pulse stutter. She wore a cloak the color of old moss, and at her hip hung a sheathed blade with runes that glowed faintly blue.

I knew the cloak.

The elf guide said, “Nyx wishes an audience with the elders. For this human.”

The elf’s gaze slid from him to Nyx, and then to me. Her eyes narrowed. The faintest line appeared between her brows.

“You,” she said.

Her voice was low, clear, and utterly cold. I had heard it only once, in a single clipped word, standing over a dead cadet in a sunlit field.

“Why have you come here?” she demanded. “I spared you once. That was a gift. Not an invitation.”

“You’re the one who killed the hunter,” I said.

“I am.”

“The twins.” The question burst from me before I could stop it. “The boy and the girl, they were with me. Are they... did they get home? Are they safe?”

For the first time, something flickered across her composure. Her lips parted slightly.

“Safe,” she said at last, stiffly. “Yes. They are safe.”

“Where?”

“That is all you need to know.”

“Please...”

“It is all you will be told.” Her eyes shifted to Nyx, and her expression softened into something wary and tender. “You vouch for him.”

“With my life,” Nyx said.

“Foolish.” But she stepped aside.

The great doors swung inward on silent hinges. Beyond them lay a vast circular chamber, lit by a ring of silver lamps. It looked like a throneroom with five thrones, and at its far end, seated on carved chairs of white wood, sat five figures in long gray robes. Their faces were ancient. Their eyes were bright and cold and fixed upon me.

“Human of the Earth academy,” said one who stood on the far left, in a voice that inspired no confidence at all. “Come forward alone. The fairy may wait outside.”

Nyx squeezed my shoulder once, hard, then slid off my shoulder.

I walked into the chamber, and the doors shut behind me.

“Now,” the one at the center said, folding her thin hands in her lap, “tell us why we should not execute you on the spot.”

# Chapter Nineteen: The Elders' Verdict

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"Because killing me will not fix anything," I said.

The woman observed me for some time.

"Speak, then."

I had rehearsed it on the walk down, and every word abandoned me. Five pairs of ancient eyes watched me from their white seats. The silver lamps hissed softly. I thought of Nyx waiting outside, and the promise I had made, and I started again.

"I'm a cadet of the Earth academy," I said. "I was sent here to kill. I've done it. I won't pretend otherwise." My voice cracked, and I let it. "But I've seen your villages, and I've seen what my people did to them. I've seen children. I don't want to be part of it anymore."

"Many cadets repent when they are caught," said the second elder, a gaunt man with a beard that looked like white cotton candy. "Fewer do it when they are free."

"I'm not asking for mercy. I'm asking for a way to end it." I took a breath. "Your people can't find the portals, if what I heard is correct. Neither can mine, not really. We only walk through them. But if they could be shut for good, nobody else would come. The killing would stop on both sides."

The chamber was silent.

"You wish," said the elder woman, "to find common ground between your people and ours."

"Yes."

"A noble thought." Her voice was almost gentle. "And a childish one."

My spine went cold.

"Do you know how many villages have burned?" The third elder, a broad woman with a battle-hardened face, leaned forward. "How many mothers have watched their young cut down by men who laughed? Your cadets have gone too far, human. We do not hate you for it. But there is no road back from where we stand."

"There must be."

"There is only one outcome." The eldest folded her hands. "Either we are destroyed, or the cadets are. We cannot share a world. We have tried to imagine it, and we cannot."

“Give me a chance to try something different.” My throat burned. “If the portals close, the academy can’t send anyone. The war on your side ends. And my people...” I stopped. I hadn’t thought of the next part more clearly. The Avarrai. The spheres. A world that depended on us leveling up.

“Your people,” the eldest said, watching me.

“They are desperate, and I do not mean this as an excuse for their deeds.”

I told them about the Avarrai. They listened with carefully contained curiosity, but the scholars in them urged them to ask more when I didn’t clarify. There was a long moment of silence afterwards, and I could not tell whether they were considering helping me or just thinking of an excuse to kill me. Then the eldest rose.

“You may wait in the gardens. We will consider your words and summon you when we have decided.”

It was a dismissal. I bowed, because I didn’t know what else to do, and a guard led me out.

The elven gardens were not like anything on Earth.

They spilled down the valley in terraces, each one a different color, silver ferns in one, blue lilies in the next, then beds of flowers that glowed faintly like embers. A stream ran through them in a tiled channel, and the water chimed as it fell. I found a stone bench at the edge of a pool and sat with my hands on my lap. For some reason, the posture reminded me of my first day at high academy.

*Childish,* the elder had said. Maybe she was right.

I did not hear the footsteps. I only noticed the shadow that fell across the water, and then the figure that settled onto the bench beside me, graceful and unhurried, as though we had arranged to meet.

It was the elf warrior. Her spear was gone, and she had taken off her cloak. Without the guard’s rigid stance, she looked less like a statue and more like a tired woman.

“You are strange,” she said.

I blinked. “Excuse me?”

“For a cadet. The others come into this world to plunder and kill. I do not understand why you would go against the wishes of your own kind, like when you spared those children.” She watched the pool. “Perhaps it is why she took to you so quickly.”

“Nyx?”

“She withdrew when her sister passed.” Her voice was quiet. “She was a child when it happened, in her heart if not her years. She stopped. She sealed herself away.” Her gaze slid to me. “And then you walked in, and she was sitting on your shoulder with a smile on her face.”

“I didn’t do anything.”

“That is the point.”

I rubbed the back of my neck. “I don’t understand.”

She was silent for some time, as if choosing her words with care.

“Her kind,” she said at last, “have an affinity for the mind and heart. They hear thoughts. They feel the weather of another’s emotions.” She turned a leaf over between her fingers. “And because of it, they are drawn to purity. To anyone whose heart is plain and unguarded. They cannot help it.”

“*Purity*,” I repeated.

“Do not flatter yourself. It is not a virtue. It is a lack of malice, a kind of openness that one is born with.” She looked at me flatly. “The fairies attach themselves to such people. It is a bond. Almost... romantic. Not in the way you might think. But close.”

My face went hot. “I never...”

“I know. It is not your doing.” She dropped the leaf. “But hear me. If you return her fondness, even in the smallest way, she will follow you to the end of the world. She will never leave your side. And she has lost everything already.”

“I’d never take advantage of her.”

“You might not intend to.” Her eyes were hard, and I saw a flicker of something fierce behind them. “I do not want you to hurt her, cadet. Not by accident. Not by kindness. Do you understand?”

“I understand.”

“Good.” She rose, smoothing her tunic. “My name is Selene, by the way. You are welcome to use it, though I would prefer you did not.”

She left without waiting for an answer.

I sat very still. It took me a long time to realize that I was smiling, and a longer time to realize it wasn’t entirely from amusement.

***

Nyx found me an hour later. She came flitting down the terraces with her arms full of flowers, blue lilies and silver ferns and little glowing buds, nearly as big as she was. A trail of petals followed her through the air. When she reached me, she dumped the whole armful in my lap and hovered back, panting, beaming.

“For you,” she said.

“For me?”

“The elves said they were for decoration. But I thought you needed them more.” She tucked a lily behind my ear, giggling. “There. Now you look like a bridegroom.”

“Nyx.”

“It’s a joke!” Her ears went pink. “Only a joke.”

I held the flowers a little closer.

The summons came at dusk. A guard came for me, and I followed him down the stone path, with Nyx perched on my shoulder, silent and tense. The doors of the great hall opened onto the same circle of lamps. Five elders waited in their chairs.

“We have deliberated,” the eldest said. I held my breath.

“Your plan is flawed. It is dangerous. It may doom your own people.” Her voice did not soften. “But it is not without merit. We will pursue it.”

I felt a wave of relief wash over me. Nyx ruffled my hair.

“But we lack the knowledge,” the eldest went on. “Our scholars have searched for an answer to the mystery of your gates for generations. We cannot see them. We cannot read them. The only beings in this world who have ever understood the lore of other dimensions are the vampires, who came to this world from elsewhere, long before you.”

The room had gone very cold.

“You will have to ask one,” said the third elder. “Not any vampire. A *true* vampire. One who has lived long enough to remember.”

“There is only one,” said the eldest. “She rules a castle in the northern snows. Her kin call her by a title I will not repeat lightly.”

I already knew. I think I had known the moment she said *vampire*.

“The Frost Empress,” she said quietly. “Feonna.”